# QUAD AND THE INDO-PACIFIC SECURITY ARCHITECTURE: INSTITUTIONALIZATION AND ITS IMPACTS

A Dissertation submitted to the Central University of Kerala in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of

**MASTER OF ARTS IN INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AND POLITICAL SCIENCE**

SUBMITTED BY

**M Prithiviraj**

**Reg. No. 2301305027**

**Under the Guidance and Supervision of**

**Dr. Reinhart Philip**

**DEPARTMENT OF INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AND POLITICS**

**SCHOOL OF GLOBAL STUDIES**

**CENTRAL UNIVERSITY OF KERALA, KASARAGOD, KERALA**

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# DECLARATION

**I, M PRITHIVI RAJ**, hereby declare that the dissertation titled **" Quad and the Indo-Pacific Security Architecture: Institutionalization and its Impacts"**, is an authentic record of research conducted by me under the guidance of **Dr. Reinhart Philip**, Assistant Professor of the department of International Relations and politics, Central University of Kerala, Kasaragod, Kerala. No part of this dissertation has been presented for the award of any other degree, diploma, title, or recognition.

Signature:

Name of the Candidate:

Date:

I hereby forward the dissertation for evaluation to the examiners concerned

Dr. Reinhart Philip

( Research Supervisor)

Date :

Place:

**DEPARTMENT OF INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AND POLITICS**

**CENTRAL UNIVERSITY OF KERALA**

## CERTIFICATE

Certified that the dissertation titled, "**Quad and the Indo-Pacific Security Architecture: Institutionalization and its Impacts"** Submitted to the Central University of Kerala by **Mr. M PRITHIVIRAJ**, under the guidance and supervision of **DR REINHART PHILIP** submitted to the Central University of Kerala in a partial fulfilment of the requirement for MA in International Relations and Political Science, no part of this dissertation has been presented for the award of any other degree, diploma, title or recognition.

Signature of the guide: Head of the Department:

Name and Designation of the Supervising Guide:

Date:

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M Prithiviraj

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**List of Abbreviations**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1) | ASEAN | Association of Southeast Asian Nations |
| 2) | AUKUS | Australia, United Kingdom, United States of America |
| 3) | ANZUS | Australia, New Zealand, United States of America |
| 4) | BRI | Belt and Road Initiative |
| 5) | BRICS | Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa |
| 6) | CPEC | China Pakistan occupied Kashmir Economic Cooperation |
| 7) | EU | European Union |
| 8) | FATF | Financial Action Task Force |
| 9) | HADR | Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief |
| 10) | IORA | Indian Ocean Regional Association |
| 11) | NATO | North Atlantic Treaty Organization |
| 12) | RCEP | Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership |
| 13) | SCO | Shanghai Cooperation Organization |
| 14) | UN | United Nations |
| 15) | UNCLOS | United Nations Convention on Laws of Seas |

# Chapter I

## Introduction

The Indo-Pacific region is in the spotlight of every nation's foreign policy. Multiple power centres are launching their Indo-Pacific policy and strategy which is the first big step towards the Asian century. While there was a reluctance to acknowledge the growth of the Asia-Pacific from the trans-Atlantic and Mediterranean politics, it did not stop only with the Asia-Pacific. Rather, it emerged as the Indo-Pacific. Since 2008, the development of China and India have started and they are hedging to secure their position in international politics and started being assertive. The global chessboard is moving towards the Indo-Pacific. Nations that kept the Indo-Pacific as a mere academic narrative have accepted the reality and undeniable growth of the Indo-Pacific region.

Though the Indo-Pacific is predominantly considered a maritime domain, growth is attributed to the littoral nations, especially the oriental world. Despite multiple nations having multiple interpretations of the geographical and strategic validity of the Indo-Pacific, one acceptable reality is that it is not the product of West. It does not fit into any Western assumption of political order. It is a reality of growing Asian nations as the West wanted to secure its position, and then it merges itself with the Indo-Pacific narrative. Unlike the other regional political narratives where the West has jurisdiction and control over it, the Indo-Pacific region does not fit into any of it. The most crucial characteristic of this idea is that it is democratic. Every nation has an equal say in it. Whether it is a security, economy or supply chain no space for monopoly exists in the Indo-Pacific. The leaders are dependent upon the intentions of the Indo-Pacific. We can draw parallels with the 9th-century Chozha dynasty, which expanded its influence from the Indian Ocean to the banks of the South China Sea; it was not imperialism but instead an effort for a rule-based order.(Rajagopal S, 2019) Ancestors from India have already laid the road map for the importance of rule-based order in the region. Rule-based order has become preeminent in the Indo-Pacific region because it is not easy for a single nation to control this complicated geography.

While the Indo-Pacific has become a reality, the first strategic parentship that emerged for this very cause of the future Indo-Pacific is the Quad. Quad, called Quadrilateral security dialogue or Quadrilateral dialogue, is still in the nascent stage of figuring out its shape but has been anchored as a pioneer of Indo-Pacific politics. No Indo-Pacific strategy or great game is above the parlance of Quad now. ASEAN is specific to a limited region as it does not extend its arm

to the East coast of Africa or the West coast of the USA. In 2004, a disastrous tsunami with a magnitude of 9.3 from the coast of Sumatra island had an impact on the Horn of Africa. The regions affected by this Tsunami perfectly fit into the geographical ambit of the Indo-Pacific. In the aftermath of the Tsunami, four vibrant democracies, India, Japan, Australia, and the USA, all with different political natures back then, came together for effective HADR and relief operations. (MEA, GOI, 2024). Back then, they wouldn't have been aware that this grouping would lead the politics of the Indo-Pacific. In 2007, the then Prime Minister of Japan, in his state visit to India, gave a speech in the Indian parliament famously called the Two Confluence of Seas speech, which played an instrumental role in the development of Quad. In his remarks, he first mentions the seas as seas of Freedom, and prosperity. The two seas he indicated are the Pacific Ocean and the Indian Ocean. He mentioned Asia as a broader Asia, which wants to Include India in the Asian part, which was first secluded as South Asia. He called the region an arc of Freedom and prosperity, which begins from the rim of Eurasia to Japan. (Shin Zo Abe, 2007). Since the traction gained, the four countries' leaders first met in 2007 on the sidelines of the ASEAN summit in Manila, Philippines. Quad was first abbreviated as the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue, for which India was uncomfortable since it maintained its strategic autonomy by not participating in any defense alliance. However, it is made clear that Quad is unlike other defense alliances and is not an alliance at all. Right after this meeting, the first nation to raise concerns was China. China immediately raised concerns that the meeting would destabilize peace and security and would pave the way for security issues of its own. It showed its strong protest. Due to the pressure, Australia took a back step, which led to the fall of the grouping immediately after the beginning. Scholars argue that it is the end of the Quad and that it can never resurge with the presence of the Chinese (Daniel Flitton, 2020). The reason for the fall is the short strategic sight and lack of cooperation among the member states. However, the beginning laid enough scope and prospects for its growth. Since 2007, when the Indo-Pacific narrative was taking a drift, Quad also grew along with it, due to which, after 2 decades, the Indo-Pacific narrative is led by the Quad members.

Quad was waiting for the right moment to resurge, and after 2007, developments in the Indo-Pacific for the next 10 years gave proper traction for Quad to resurge. The unexpected growth of China in a short span of time, its assertive move in the South China Sea, and its territorial dispute with India, Japan and the Philippines were all factors that gave Quad traction and resurge. Finally, in 2017, at the sideline of the East Asian summit in Manila, efforts to restart Quad started.(Samir Saran, 2024). Quad raised up precisely from the same place where it fell.

The Doklam stand-off in the India-Bhutan China tri-junction accelerated India to engage actively in a deterrence mechanism against China, but not out rightly; Quad emerged as the first best option. In 2017, the first officers-level meeting began, which soon got traction into a ministerial-level meeting.

Meanwhile, the main factor for the quick growth is the bilateral relations between the four member states, which saw an unexpected surge. All four leaders felt confident in each other, paving a high level of lateral ties, especially between India, Japan, and the USA. India again plays the most crucial role in the Quad. Without India, the entire idea of Quad would collapse. In 2016, India and the USA signed the first LEMOA agreement, which paved the way for India and US naval ships to have a port call in counterpart ports, a breakthrough in the defense relationship between India and the USA (PIB, GOI, 2016). The 2+2 dialogue mechanism between India, Japan, and India USA became a hit. In 2019, a significant development happened in the future of Quad when the foreign ministers of Quad first met in 2017 on the sidelines of the UNGA assembly in New York. It was when the first official idea of a Free, Open, and Inclusive Indo-Pacific was unveiled. These three terms, Free, Open, and Inclusive, are instrumental in guiding Quad (PIB, 2018).

Every action taken in Quad keeps any of these ideas in the centre. The term Open has a direct security connotation, which can be interpreted as a positive notion of security. It was also the first time a joint statement of all four countries was issued. From the meeting, all four ministers showed enthusiasm to take the meeting to a summit-level meeting. However, the global pandemic broke the growth of Quad. But in 2021, when the world was returning to normalcy, the Quad leaders thought the pandemic itself was an essential opportunity to engage together. The pandemic brought nations and states together for vaccine-sharing humanitarian support. The Quad which was first formed with a humanitarian intention played a leadership role in pandemic and ensured adequate availability of vaccine and other life saving equipment to the needed countries. Quad changed the pandemic from a threat into an opportunity. Finally, in 2021, the first leadership-level meeting in March 2021 in virtual mode. As a first step, Quad pledged to end the pandemic and promised to supply 1 billion COVID-19 vaccines to the Indo-Pacific countries. This commitment showed the world that Quad does not restrict itself to China or a strategic alliance but rather a development partnership with a shared vision for the future. The Quad upheld all the theoretical propositions of the Democratic peace theory as Democracy is the cornerstone of Quad (MEA, GOI, 2021). It also reiterated its commitment to a free, open, and inclusive Indo-Pacific, an Indo-Pacific not under the influence of a single state. Maritime

security is the top priority for the nations. Quad countries are committed to taking joint actions to prevent the supply chains of the Indo-Pacific and focus on nontraditional security issues, notably terrorism, piracy, and arms trafficking. Since then, the leaders have committed to meeting every year in person to solidify Quad's position in Indo-Pacific and international politics. In September 2021, the Quad leaders met in Washington, DC, for the first time in person. Since then, the Quad leaders have met every year in person and set to push the limits of Quad to new levels, still ensuring its roots of a free, open, inclusive Indo-Pacific(MEA, GOI, 2021).

However, Quad still exists as an informal mini-lateral. It is not institutionalized, nor is it a charter kind of development has not happened so far. The Quad leaders still make informal commitments and ensure they meet their word. To achieve their common goals, they have formed joint working groups for specific purposes, such as vaccine diplomacy, critical technologies, and climate change. They have not outrightly mentioned any nation's activity in the region; however, they showed concern and condemned the activities of North Korea's nuclear aggression, which is a clear reflection that Quad is concerned with security, too. The main reason argued by scholars for Quad not being institutionalized is that it will poke the Chinese and make them more aggressive. Some say that it might also instigate an arms race in the region. India is especially concerned about institutionalization as it shares a direct border with China. Multiple blockades existed before Quad, which prevented it from being institutionalized. First, it is criticized as a club of countries and represents Asian NATO. China describes Quad as Asian NATO in multiple places. Next is ASEAN's concern that the Institutionalization of Quad might shift the centrality of Indo-Pacific from ASEAN to Quad (Felix Heiduk & Thomas Wilkin,2024).

There are also differences of opinion among Quad members. As the USA wants Quad to bring a defense and security angle, India and Australia are reluctant to agree with the idea. However, the tractions so far since 2007 are positive, as institutionalization might be the need of the hour. There are multiple strategies and consultations associated with the process. If institutionalization is about to happen, what kind of grouping will it become, who will be the members, and will there be scope for an expansion? The idea of Quad+ is already on the floor to include South Korea and Vietnam in the process. If so, how will it expand? If security becomes a priority, against which country will it make its strategies? For security defense, cooperation is essential. How will defense cooperation evolve in the future? However, as the significance and importance of the Indo-Pacific region is growing and takes centre stage in the

international political economy, threats will also emerge. It is essential to establish order in the region before investments. Quad plays a critical role in ensuring order in the region. The biggest question is whether Quad will be successful in providing order in the region and maintaining a free, open, and inclusive Indo-Pacific region without being Institutionalized. It is vital to study whether the Indo-Pacific security architecture strengthens and strengthens with Quad's institutionalization. This dissertation tries to answer such questions on how important and beneficial it will be to the Indo-Pacific's security architecture by institutionalizing and, most importantly, how it serves the interest of the Quad members.

**Statement of problem:**

Indo-Pacific region has gained high stakes in current turbulent international politics. It encompasses all the current leading narratives including West vs China, claimed Chinese aggression and expansionism, Global South narrative, growth of Asian economies, West vs Rest. Indo-pacific plays a crucial role in all these narratives. However it lacks an Institutional mechanism. Quad partnership of Australia, India, Japan, United States of America have performed well in their ambitions and are potential partnership to be institutionalized. Is this institutionalization mechanism feasible if so what are the individual members states gameplay in this cause. How is the institutionalization will overall reflect in strengthening the Indo-Pacific security architecture.

**Relevance/ Scope of the Study**

The scope of the study is an attempt to understand the developments of Quad vis a vis Indo-Pacific security mechanism. It is not only crucial for India but important in global context. Given its prominence in supply chain, ecological importance, geo-political character a rule based order is important. This study aims to find how Quad can help in the process especially how does the institutionalization of Quad can help in strengthening the security of Indo-Pacific region.

**Purpose**

This study seeks to explore the possibilities of Institutionalization of Quad and what steps does each member states are taking for the purpose and their opinion on institutionalization. By finding the possibility of the event to occur it also aims to find how will it affect the existing process and developments of Indo-Pacific region.

**Objectives**

1) To examine the need for Institutionalization of Quad
2) To understand the member states countries expectations and strategies using Quad
3) To find how will it impact the Indo-pacific security architecture,

**Research Questions**

1) To what extent institutionalization of Quad reflects positively in the interest of member states?
2) Whether the Institutionalization of Quad will strengthen the Indo-Pacific security architecture?

**Methodology**

This study implies qualitative research process including the means of methodology

Literature review; To understand the current developments using existing literature

Primary data sources from official policies, statements, agreements, declaration, communique from the member states

Case studies: previous events and developments in the Indo-Pacific region.

Secondary data sources from acclaimed journals, articles,

**Chapterization**

Chapter 1: Introduction

Chapter2: Quad: A security perspective

Chapter 3: Individual Member states take on Quad`s Institutionalization

Chapter 4 : Impacts of Institutionalization process of Quad in Indo-Pacific security architecture and challenges

Chapter 5: Conclusion

**Review of Literature**

1) Kate Sullivan de Estrada (2023) in his article 'India and order transition in the Indo-Pacific: resisting the Quad as a 'security community' write how Quad as a security partnership emerged over a period of time. As the Quad democracies keeps Free and Open Indo-Pacific as a key tag line of the partnership despite not having a security angle so far it in directly reinforces security as a primary objective of this grouping. Kate instates that Free and Open Indo Pacific is not a strategy of these democracies rather a shared value. It is that shared value which brings these democracies together. Given the Chinese assertiveness and aggression beyond the South China sea as its strategic documents clearly mentions it ambition of becoming a global super power free and openness can also be considered as a counter strategy. Engagements of these democracies since 2017 is a clear reflection of commitment of the nations to stand by their shared values. Though in the individual and joint statements security is not directly mentioned, all the efforts the Quad puts through by different work means securitization. Their intention to promote Quad as a mechanism of regional stability and prosperity without hurting ASEAN is a very calculated and controlled move. The Quad members have a great value of security and linkages. Indias renewed and fresh commitments since 2017 boosts the Quad performance where success and failure of this partnership all resides with India. The way the grouping evolves having its own checks and balances without being driven by a single partners interest will not makes it a defence alliance but as security cooperation of shared interest. Despite the baseless acquisitions by the Chinese as Asian NATO, it does not disrupt or questions the validity of the Quad in international forum. Kate argues Quad as a security community is the argument both Quad and Indo-Pacific are primarily driven by shared interest of counter balancing China. As the institutionalization prospect, USA, Japan, Australia are enthusiastic about it India shows reluctance over its strategic autonomy policy as it worries that whether it would bring them part of West led camp which India was not a part of before. India`s resistance might alter the future of the Quad partnership, yet as so far it shows Quad as a steady progress, every nation is carefully taking steps over the cause.

2) Antara Ghosal Singh (2016) in his article India, China and the US: strategic convergence in the Indo-Pacific opens eye of how does the inter play between these there most important nations of the 21st century shapes the security of Indo-Pacific

region. It makes a strategic triangle of three nations carefully balancing and the other two and moving ahead in the region. So it brings to a 3 school of thought from the pivot of the triangle perspective. US has always considered security as a shared responsibility and its external policies begins and ends with American security. It wants to ensure a collective effort towards a secure, stable Asia Pacific. However for that cause to be successful role of India is undeniable, but India has always been not associated with the Asia-Pacific narrative as it is restricted within Indian Ocean. For that sake, the US led the narrative change from the Asia Pacific to Indo-Pacific. China`s vison in the region is to be asserted as common, comprehensive and cooperative security architecture. But it also apprehends about USA`s interest in the region with the world greatest Naval power it automatically paves way for hedging in the region. India`s vision it simple. To stay as the net security power in the region and as a responsible regional player to lead the maritime security construct beyond its near shores. But there are contradictions between these members itself. India doesn't want Quad to be portrayed as a defence grouping led by the US. It will give a chance for the Chinese to be more aggressive. However China`s dependency on the Indian Ocean for its critical energy supply and India`s control vis a vis Strait of Malacca keeps the calculations balanced from both sides. China also wants to evolve as an alternate security provider in the region and it activities in Sri Lanka, Maldives add value to this argument. US concern is where whether the region will be dominated by the Chinese interest and Chinese concern is that whether the region will be dominated by US interest and India`s concern is where whether there will be no rule based order in the region and peace will be de stabilized for the power politics. Keeping interest intact, these three nations interplay and partnership decides the growing security dynamics of the region and how it will impact the other regional . players in the region. Author suggests a India-US-China security dialogue can solve all the mysteries in the region.

3) Cheng-Chwee Kuik (2023) in his article Shades of grey: riskification and hedging in the Indo-Pacific deals with how Indo-Pacific has moved from a narrative in papers to real time space where conflicts and hedging happens in real time. Indo-Pacific has moved from a strategic concept to a geo political reality. Though it emerged in 2007 and lost shape immediately since 2017, it is gaining momentum since 2017. Riskification and hedging behaviour arises in South-China sea and scholars worry if not contained it may spill over to the Indian Ocean and Pacific Ocean as well. Hedging

necessarily results from process of identifying and weighing risks choosing what means and pathways are available for reducing the risk. While ASEAN intentionally wants to stay out of this power politics individual members ASEAN, Philippines, Indonesia, Malaysia are caught off guard with the hedging race with China. Here is where emergence Quad reflects as a positive note for the Quad countries from the emerging risk. It is no longer deniable that the Indo-Pacific region is devoid of risk. It is devoid of harm but not risks. The risks when not treated in a timely manner emerges into a harm as how it had emerged in the South China sea region. As multiple partners including the European counterparts such as France, Germany is interested over the region and the African members voices where always muted in big power politics the region has now to accommodate more strategies and calculations than ever before. The South China region remains to be the principle security issue of the region. With that the Chinese assertiveness is validated a mechanism like Quad becomes extremely important to prevent the spill over and increasing tensions. Quad though seen as a democratic partnership for growth might have security prospects in the future the hedging angle is already with it since its birth, if not China would have not been that apprehensive about formation of Quad and called it an Asian NATO. Some parallels can be drawn from the Euro-Atlantic partnership and the Indo-Pacific partnership where both emerged out of distress. Where some scholars argue that Quad might heat up the regional politics, hedging as already started and by not validating Quad the hedging will also not stop.

4) In the Institute of South Asian Studies of the National University of Singapore`s article on Institutionalising the Quad: Can it Seize the Momentum for the Future? Article the authors have hit the direct question of this research whether the institutionalization of the Quad is the need of the hour if there is momentum for it the results are mixed yet promising. Quad promisingly working on the future of the Indo-Pacific region the prospects of its institutionalization cannot be out rightly rejected just because it not happening now. US so far is the hegemon of the region according to the authors, and coming of Quad has given more space for the new partners in the region including India, Australia and Japan. Quad is the reflection of the democratic establishment of its members and it fights the hegemonic and autocratic interest of member in the region. One great challenge and opportunity is that over reliance of China in the region

especially by ASEAN. However ASEAN has maintained a neutral stance between the West and the Chinese, growing Chinese aggression in South China has created two blocs within the ASEAN advocating to take a hard stance on the Chinese. Regional perspectives of the Quad member seems to be divergent but the point they try to attain is the same. Australia once had high level of trading with the Chinese is now skeptic of the partnership of China. Japan have issues over the Senkaku island dispute and China has emerged as a immediate regional threat for them in East Asia. USA through Quad wants to put an end to the Chinese assertion who is its main hegemonic rival. If Us had an intention lead the region via Quad it will not be possible for them is the whole idea of Quad is democratic. India here has a most advanced vision of Quad which does not stop with China. It wants a free open Indo-Pacific where all partners are equal with resilient supply chain. India`s interest is upheld just by ensuring the region is not dominated by any partner in the region. Quad is clearly not a club. It is open for all open for deliberations. The idea of Quad plus has also gained traction including New Zealand, South Korea and Vietnam. But will it add character to Quad is a separate question to be studies. However looking at the developments so the prospects for institutionalizing Quad is not out rightly rejected where multiple factors are associated both in offensive and defensive side to deal with.

5) Patrick Gerard Buchan et.al (2020) in Defining the Diamond The Past, Present, and Future of the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue, takes a detour the genesis of Quad how it evolved its current presence and what is the future of the Quad in coming times and what are the roles it has to do with. The genesis of Quad goes to the 2004 Tsunami where 4 democracies decide to come together to help the people in distress especially the South east Asia and the Eastern shores of India and Andaman Nicobar islands. From the idea of these nation coming together looks so fresh with no political ambitions or hedging interest. But once the strategic calculation of the grouping is weighed it is understood that it can do more than the disaster relief part. Existing political condition was also favour of on this drift. The momentum did not gain immediately rather a slow focused process. Each development with the Quad was taken so carefully including how it will named. Shi zo Abe the former prime minister of Japan played an instrumental and pivotal role in the bringing up and development of this Quad from an idea to an operation unit. US already had a string presence in the region and with coming of Quad a strong democratic and liberal value was installed to it making it a

structural organization with a right cause. While in 2007 it got a shape it had to be called down immediately due to lack of confidence within members and external pressure. But in 2017, when the revival happened the partners were so confident and purposeful for why the development is happening. Quad is not a rapid institutionalization rather a gradual convergence. It had regional interest and global interest prior to its individual national interest. The study also held a small survey among the intellectual community revolving around Quad countries. Every nation is in favour of the annual leadership level meeting wit the head of the state level summits to happen every year. When it comes to institutionalization the interest was mixed. India was quite doubtful about the process and consequences of the process. However the need is not completely ruled out also.

6) Rahul Roy-Chaudhury & Kate Sullivan de Estrada (2018) in their article India, the Indo-Pacific and the Quad, emphasize the importance of India in the Indo-Pacific and how India`s positioning in Quad has help to achieve its Indo-Pacific dream. In 2018, the Pacific command of the US Navy was renamed as the Indo-Pacific command. Earlier decades US used Asia Pacific as a notion to express the region which was okay with China too. Later slowly the narrative Asia-Pacific changed into Indo-Pacific where now term Asia-Pacific becomes non-existent except Chinas led agendas. This change of narrative and lexicon of Indo-Pacific shows clear relevance of Indian Oceans role in the emerging doctrines and India`s geo politics and geo strategy leading the Indian ocean geo politics. The term Indo-Pacific is a recognition of India`s growth. India is clear that the Indian Ocean is not an arena of power politics or rivalry rather a space of partnership for all like minded democracies. That is also a reason why India`s hesitant over bringing more security angle to Quad and institutionalization to a larger context. Narratively speaking Indian Ocean`s centrism in Indo-Pacific is important but should properly co exist with the ASEAN`s way of Indo-Pacific. The reason for the growth of the relevance is very obvious that its China. As the Trump 2.0 moves towards Russia rapprochement, it will still go hard on the Chinese, and Indo-Pacific is a region prone to more skirmishes. Chinese military level engagement in the Indian Ocean is a clear concern for democracies and especially for India, where a partnership like Quad gets more relevance. China`s permanent presence in Djibouti, partnership with the Pakistan for 8 submarines and helping growing the naval capabilities of Bangladesh, Myanmar clearly shows the engagement with the South Asian partners are primarily maritime. It

is clearly visible that its beyond securing its supply chains, rather a direct engagement to influence. In that terms India`s positioning in Quad becomes crucial. It is beyond China that India`s presence will make Quad not as a bloc but a partnership. Quad loses its track without India and US knows it very well.

7) Jagannath Panda & Daewon Ohn (04 Oct 2024) in their article, Minilateralism and the new Indo-Pacific order: theoretical ambitions and empirical realities, sets a institutional narrative of how Indo-Pacific is a region that accommodates more mini laterals and mini laterals might be the future of the Indo-Pacific region. Since Mini laterals are specific dealing a cause of immediate need, flexible and quickly executable it meets the pace of growing relevance of the Indo-Pacific. Especially in terms of security and trade mini laterals are more relevant over the multi laterals. Quad is a classic example of a mini lateral structure is sizeably impacting the Indo-Pacific order. Other mini laterals in the region include AUKUS, I2US2, trilateral security dialogue each has a different purpose and each with a specific reason. AUKUS emerged as a pure military alliance for the West to extend its nuclear umbrella to Australia. I2U2 specifically to forge the multi ethnic democracies for dialogue and Quad has more angle and determination yet to un earthed. There are multiple partners interested in the Indo-Pacific including the Europeans especially the French with direct presence in the region, Southeast to uphold the ASEAN centrality and the South Pacific island nations despite small has a considerable voice. Almost every region interested in it, the region itself becomes a mini representation of international order. Quad ahs also emerged as a balance o power mechanism in the region by counter balancing growing Chinese assertiveness. China also dubbed this mechanism by unveiling RCEP and BRI which are primarily economic partnership. However the projects and commitments part of this initiative are beyond economic rather strategic. Strategic factor of China makes it impediment to evolve Quad as a balance of power mechanism. Quad also ensures the region is democratic by not giving space for an individual nation to dominates which is a unique speciality of the region on its own. Quad though having four members currently will not restrict or confines with same in the future. All the Quad members have clearly committed that Quad is not a bloc. In that case the discussions for Quad+ is already on cards with Republic of Korea, New Zealand, Vietnam showing interest in the mechanism. If once this gets kicks off more partners might be interested in the process to involve in this

strategic checkers. Quad which was criticized for not being fit into any box it is clearly mini lateral.

8) Ghulam Ali (2024), in his article Territorial disputes, the role of leaders and the impact of Quad: a triangular explanation of China-India border escalations, touches one of the most important stressing areas of this research that how doe the Indo-Chinese relations especially the relations at the border reflects in the Quad. Author says, India`s strategic advantage in balancing China and help strengthening the India`s positioning in the Quad. From 2013 to 2024 7 major border escalation happened in the borders which is the highest since the independence of both the countries. This bored development is directly associated with how Quad evolves and perceived. China`s assertion in both the borders and South Asian partners concern India as it feels circled. However the main reason behind India being hesitant over not making Quad more security focused it that it would aggravate border situation. But, the situation is going to remain same despite any developments happening in the waters. The Dokhlam standoff in 2017 paved way for a quick escalation in India`s decision to take Quad seriously and go beyond the level that it was hesitant before. The Chinese rival factor for India is crucial factor in building Quad. India`s growing relations with individual members of Quad also signifies the same. India-Japan relations which were steady through out is now seeing a spike in the process taking new ventures including defence and security, maritime domain awareness. The 2+2 mechanism between the ministerial level leadership is breakthrough in the future of relations. Similarly with Australia too the engagement has paced up. India`s active participation in its defence exercises, leadership level visits all adds more prominence to the bi lateral relations which also will reflect positively within the Quad. It is one of the important player and a card for India`s strategic dominance in the maritime geo strategic space. The border dispute has direct relationship with how assertive India will make moves in other spaces. While India is looking for a permanent solution in the borders to settle the conflicts, the Chinese tend to play it as a card for their needs at their own disposal. In such sense India is also now moving from a defensive to defensive offensive approach which will pave way for more engagement with Quad in order to balance the Chinese growing threats.

9) Felix Heiduk & Thomas Wilkins (28 Oct 2024), in their article, Minilateralism and pathways to institutional progression: alliance formation or cooperative security governance, makes an extensive effort to find how does the minilaterals operate in a security domain and how it differs from alliance formation to the cooperative security governance mechanism. Mini laterals are nascent grouping which emerges with a specific purpose which can evolve into any form as it need. It can also become a multilateral when its scopes expands, or as an alliance when one partner leads or a security partnership when every stake holder has equal space in it. The factors that leads to the rise of mini laterals predominantly are, duality of economy and strategic competition. In the current scenario the Asia-Pacific region has emerged as checking ground for mini laterals. More minilaterals emerge in the Easten part of the Greenwich, which multi ethnic, complicated and prone to many security issues. The usual scale of a mini lateral is between 3-9 and it is dependent upon structure, functionality and purpose. The structure can be legal, binding, and also informal. Speaking about functionality it can address a specific issues after which it may go irrelevant or can also have broad and dynamic purpose to stay. Taking mini laterals into international security domain, there will be layers of regional security architecture operating at multiple levels. Usually security grouping are multi lateral but it can also mini lateral depending upon the region and players. However the process of transition of these mini laterals from just an informal discussion or a narrative to an institution is gradual. For example, ASEAN started as a mini lateral with a short vision, but the needs evolved its growth and now its one of the successful multi lateral. These mini laterals sometimes are also called as proto alliances. Indo-pacific region is currently looking for an alternative from bi lateral and multilateral and is looking for an issue specific process oriented mini laterals. These mini laterals are capable of functioning as a hybrid institutions and also stay informal. In security aspect the difference in mini laterals are whether they are formal military alliance or a cooperative security governance. But institutionalization requires high level of strategic adjustment, which for now Quad is struggling to find. But it has a potential to emerge as a cooperative security governance mechanism on which it will be legitimate, democratic and will not serve any nation`s particular agenda. It can also face criticisms like Asian NATO in a better manner.

10) Gorana Grgić (2024) in his article, Redefining NATO's Indo-Pacific partnerships: cooperative security meets collective defence and deterrence, the author finds the

nuance space between alliances and coalitions which becomes a strategic partnership. Based on the type of arrangement of security partnership in a specific region the definition of security moves from narrow to broad. For example in Taiwan strait the ambit of security is so specific to China`s action and Taiwan and is partners response. But in case of the Indo-Pacific the definition is broad and multi dimensional. With regard to the Indo-Pacific the nature of the security partnership experiments is to cooperate not contest. The design of the regional construct of Indo-Pacific is not very much habited to contest or hedge. NATO which is specifically to a regions collective defence mechanism, to the trans Atlantic region is now beyond Atlantic. Both in idea and regional terms its influence has expanded. Initially the purpose of the creation of NATO is to prevent US and Europe from the aggression of Cold-War and to be a collective nuclear deterrent to a specific region. After the end of cold war tis initial purpose was fulfilled yet it remains strong. Because NATO has re adopted it purpose expanded its scope beyond Russia. Similarly in geography their role has gone beyond Atlantic has also started to influence in the Indo-Pacific region too. Individual member states relationship with NATO is extortionary that Japan, South Korea, Taiwan has a close relation with the NATO. From defence to intelligence sharing the scope is large. The Euro-Atlantic and Indo-Pacific merger in terms of security is a reflection of larger stride of the international community for strategic security partnership. It can also be criticized as a Western influence yet it successfully ensuring the rule based order in the region. The Chinese part will surely not be happy with NATO involving in the Indo-Pacific since they are aware of the fact that NATO does not restricts its scope only with Russia. Japan may act a key player bridging NATO with the Indo-Pacific security mechanism. South Korea already has direct communication with NATO, which it considers as a strategic deterrence to growing China-Russia-North Korea nexus. If North Korea can send its troops to Eastern borders of Ukraine to fight the European war NATO cannot sit tight in Europe saying North Korea is not in the geographical ambit of its creation. In such sense developing strategic factors will give more scope for the NATO to play a sizeable role in Indo-Pacific security which will impact the non NATO members such as India and ASEAN. If NATO were to play a role the these nations looks it with a skepticsm that as a Western enforcement. Its impacts will be visible in regional arrangement like Quad too.

# Chapter II

## Quad: A Security perspective

### Early Developments 2004 to 2017

In 2004, When the Quad tsunami core group was formed, the entire scope of Quad was restricted to humanitarian assistance and disaster relief(MEA, GOI, 2017). However, in 2024, a foreign ministerial-level meeting of the Quad's joint statement mentioned the security issues in the Korean peninsula, while both Korea is not part of this grouping. The Quad has reshaped its agenda from time to time, and its security perspective has also slowly evolved over the period. However, the pace and progress is slow but not stagnated. The Quad leaders re-instated that Quad is strictly not a military group but does not restrict itself to military grouping in international political system security discourses. Quad takes this niche area of a nonmilitary strategic partnership with security relevance. The early tides of Quad was from 2004 to 2007 and its informal dissolution post-2008 to the resurgence in 2017. Security was a little much of a concern for the grouping. But the geo-political developments in the Indo-Pacific from 2007 to 2017 played a crucial role in Quad's security point of view, and in 2017, when Quad 2.0 resurged, security impeded its revival. China's sudden growth in the South China Sea, especially in the construction of artificial islands, has begun militarizing the South China Sea. The second factor is in 2013, the standoff between China and the Philippines over the Scarborough Shoal heightened the tensions. In 2016, the Permanent Court of Arbitration gave a verdict in favor of the Philippines yet, China failed to comply with it. In 2014, China launched its ambitious Belt and Road Initiative to revive its old Silk Road and came up with the idea of the maritime Silk Road to exert its influence in the marine domain too. It showed their clear interest beyond the South China Sea. In 2007, Shin Zo Abe's visit to India stressed the importance of protecting the crucial sea lines of communication. He also noted that the India-Japan security partnership should reach greater heights. During this period, the members' Individual defense and security partnership was given more importance. In the 2017 first meeting after the beginning of Quad 2.0, all four nations issued separate statements. While India refrained from using words denoting maritime security or freedom of navigation, Japan and the USA mentioned Quad's commitment to include a value-based, free, open, and inclusive Indo-Pacific region. It has also re-instated its position to accept the ASEAN-centric Indo-Pacific where Quad is not a competition to any regional grouping but rather

complementary(MEA, GOI, 2021). The idea of security that Quad is trying to posture is not a negative connotation of security where a proper alliance will be formed to deter a common aggressor. Instead, Quad has ambitions to move to a positive connotation of security where it helps in securing the existing mechanisms that are not directly associated with security but rather elements such as patrol and surveillance, intelligence sharing, and domain awareness, which will indirectly aid in security(Samir Saran, 2024).

**Maritime Security and Quad**

As the term Indo-Pacific denotes the grouping of the nations associated with two Oceans, the Indian Ocean and Pacific Ocean, Maritime security plays a crucial role in the security angle of the Quad. Over fifty percent of global trade transits and forty percent of oil trade transits through the region. The Malacca Strait, a critical choke point in the Indo-Pacific, handles goods transit worth three trillion US dollars annually. Key developing nations of the current order, India and China, are heavily dependent on the sea line of communication that runs through the Indo-Pacific. Quad considers the maritime security of the Indo-Pacific as a top priority as the term free and open Indo-Pacific exactly means the freedom to navigation and open for all characters of the region. The value-based partnership is so sure that it doesn't want the region to be dominated by any single player. The first mention of maritime security in the Indo-Pacific came in the joint statement of the 2022 summit(Manoj Joshi, 2020). It mentioned the need to adhere to rule-based order in the region to maintain the freedom of navigation and overflight. The inference here is that any interference to freedom of navigation or overflight is a direct security concern, and by ensuring its freedom, Quad takes its first significant step beyond its values to mention these points directly in their joint statements. Next, it mentioned the adherence to the United Nations Convention on Laws of Seas (UNCLOS). The Philippines primary complaint about China is its non-adherence to UNCLOS.

The next necessary inference is that, while previous statements mention the Indo-Pacific region, which it breaks as the Indian Ocean and the Pacific Ocean, the statement extends to mentioning the East China and South China Sea outrightly, and these expectations apply to those regions as well. East China and South China sea are directly influenced if China and Quad members mention the region's security is a clear statement of Quad's commitment to maritime security. The statement also mentioned that it "opposes any coercive, provocative or unilateral actions that seek to change the status quo and increase tensions in the area, such as the militarization of disputed features, the dangerous use of coast guard vessels and maritime

militia, and efforts to disrupt other countries' offshore resource exploitation activities" (Quad Joint statement, 2022). The Coast Guard vessels of China went on confrontations with the Filipino and Vietnamese fisher communities. This statement directly mentions its commitment to the maritime security of the Indo-pacific. Since 2007 its direct commitment to maritime security issues been big breakthrough Quad's evolution in the domain that maritime security of the Indo-Pacific.

**Quad Maritime Security Working Group**

A vital breakthrough happened in the sidelines of the 2023 foreign ministers meeting of the Quad countries. Since Quad is an informal mini-lateral without an institutional framework, it carries out its joint commitments and works by creating ad hoc working groups. This style began in the 2004 tsunami when specific working groups were made. Since 2017, the leaders have initiated various working groups to carry out a particular task. It includes COVID-19 vaccine distribution working groups, Climate action working groups, and terrorism working groups. In the context of the security evolution of Quad, this maritime security working group is a breakthrough. As Quad sticks to its values of a free, open Indo-Pacific and in their joint statements of 2022, where they mentioned the need for a better approach to maritime security, a special working group for this cause was devised. As institutionalism scholars argue, these working groups are joint actions of working, which is a prerequisite to building an institutional structure. As these working groups have a formal structure, it is a big step towards institutionalization as it follows a specific process and structure. In 2024, foreign ministers met, and the ministers showed interest in having a maritime legal dialogue as a part of this working group. From this they are interested in taking this working group as practical machinery to carry out joyous legal and lawful tasks to strengthen the Indo-Pacific security architecture (MEA, GOI, 2023). In June 2024, a joint working group on maritime security was held in Sydney, where diplomats from all 4 countries participated, according to the official Instagram handle of the Ministry of External Affairs of India(PIB, 2024).

Quad tries to put maritime security under the disguise of nontraditional maritime security, where it also works along in cyber security and critical technologies. Since the Quad is not a military alliance or a grouping focused specifically on security cooperation, it lacks traditional security areas, especially state security (Kate Sullivan Estrada, 1018). Quad is conscious about not drifting away from its focus as a development partnership yet not staying away from pressing issues of security. In the Indo-Pacific mechanism, though formal organizations such

as IORA and BIMSTEC exist, their scope in security is limited. There is an enormous vacuum in a homegrown security policy for the region. Quad tries to fill up the space. It acts as a mechanism to bridge Indo-Pacific with international documents of security including UNCLOS, the UN. Since these nations firmly believe in international law, instead of writing its own interest-based laws, it ensures the existing international laws are strictly followed in the region. In 2022 another working group on maritime domain awareness is also created to strengthen the maritime domain awareness in the area which will positively reflect in the maritime security. Instead of a negative approach, Quad takes the positive approach of peace and security via joint working groups (S L Narashiman, 2024).

**Nontraditional security issues and counter-terrorism**

Mitigating nontraditional security issues such as climate change and controlling rampant terrorism and piracy activity in the Indo-Pacific remains Quad's top priority. In the 2023 foreign ministers meeting of Quad, Counter Terrorism Working Group was created. Immediately after is creation the first official level meeting held in Honolulu in December 2023(MEA, GOI, 2023). The working groups is designed to meet every year to discuss the relevant issues of terrorism in Indo-Pacific. It aims to work on emerging areas like Unmanned Aerial Vehicle (UAV) usage by terror outfits, using the internet for terror propaganda, etc.

Quad also aims to focus on unregulated illegal fishing (IUU) and other illegal activities and sea usage. This counter-terror effort by Quad is more beneficial for India, as India is the worst victim of terrorism. In recent times, terrorism is taking a maritime route and actions, making it more challenging to mitigate. The Read Sea crisis by the Houthi rebels is the best example to show to what extent now international terrorism is waterborne. As part of the working group activities, officials conducted multiple tabletop exercises, noted the 2024 statement on the joint working group (Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Japan, 2024). The 2025 session of the group is scheduled to happen in India. In the security quest for Quad non, traditional areas remain top priority. As the region under the Indo-Pacific is too vast and unregulated with a lack of institutional enforcement, it is prone to terror activities. Since the grouping cannot engage in direct traditional concerns, non traditional security issues will be best to start. Once it has done commendable work in the nonconventional space, it can slowly expand its security discourses umbrella to the need-based issues. Quad leader's joint statement of 2024 has directly condemned the activities of North Korea in its nuclear weapon program. The leaders accused the North Korean counterpart that their actions are destabilizing and asked to refrain from

further provocation and stick to the international norms. In 2025 the Quad is set to unfold its ambitious idea of 'Quad at sea observers mission'. This observer mission comprises the Coast Guards of all four countries and aims to have joint discussions on critical security concerns. It also envisions a joint working and exercise by the Coast Guard, which is the first of a kind, bringing armed forces inside the policy actions Quad. Despite the complications, Quad ensures nontraditional security issues can be contained only through international cooperation and is open to working more on the problems(Kabir Taneja, 2023).

**Free, Open, Inclusive Indo-Pacific- Looking the values of Quad from security angle**.

The Quad leaders consider this partnership as a value-based partnership. They refer to their common interest in the region and that interest brought them together. In multiple interviews, the leaders have positioned itself as a development partnership. Especially development pertained to current areas of relevance. The development doctrines and development policy analysis says security impedes development to happen (Kate Sullivan de Estrada,2023). A classic example is the African continent. Despite multiple efforts by various agencies in Africa working for the concerned development, due to the security crisis, unstable nature, and law and order crisis, actual development has failed. This condition holds good in any region of the world. If development were to occur in the Indo-Pacific region, it should be threat- and risk-free. Looking specific to the Indo-Pacific security crisis may arise from multiple angles, traditional, nontraditional, terror, climate, etc. Every other scholar who works on Indo-pacific and watchers admit that Chinese action in the Indo-Pacific region is aggressive and they are liable to multiple illegal activities in Indo-Pacific. However, China upholds its good leadership posture no matter what and criticizes Quad as Asian NATO. Having such a partner in the neighbor and including direct traditional element of security concern will further boils the trouble. However, Quad nations did not give up just because of the Chinese condemnation still, and this partnership ensures a secure Indo-Pacific by strengthening the legal and moral mechanism in the Indo-Pacific. The values of the Indo-Pacific also have a security angle to it. The word free in every document of Quad denotes free from threat, free from aggression, free from influence, free from occupation, free from fear and terror, and free from anything that destabilizes Indo-Pacific. If China were to take Overt action in the region against the legal norms, then Quad will not hesitate to run against it because if it fails to do so, the partnership loses its value ( Antara Goshal Singh, 2023). Next significant value being 'Open' Indo-Pacific. The Chinese nine-dash line focuses on encircling the South China Sea through an imaginary line to secure its predominance. The idea of open is opposite to what China does in neighbours

waters. Scholars proposed China's string of pearls strategy, where it intends to encircle India through economic cooperation with South Asian partners to sabotage India's hold in the region. These activities are against what Quad calls for an Open Indo-Pacific where navigation in sea and overflight will not be disrupted and will open for all partners. Next being 'Inclusive' the Quad is against any unilateral action or opinion regarding Indo-Pacific. Even the Quad members does not have a solitary interest on the region but it is always shared (Antara Goshal Singh, 2016). The French has given its policy on the Indo-Pacific, and in 2019, ASEAN came up with an outlook of the Indo-Pacific. The European Union has also devised an Indo-Pacific policy which the Quad nations welcomes.

The Quad wants to provide equal space for every partner in the world for the betterment of the world. The word inclusive ensures equitable sharing of resources, equal share in decision making, ensuing all voices are heard. Though not mentioning security directly, all these values support safe Indo-Pacific without any threats. The Copenhagen school of security says there is a security angle associated with every non-security narrative and the process is called securitization. These values are similar to the embryo of the seed which has security roots but is not outrightly mentioned. It if doesn't have a security perspective associated with it the Chinese wont be too furious on Quad (Rahul Roy-Chaudhury & Kate Sullivan de Estrada,2018).

**Interpreting Joint Statements since 2017 on security imperatives**

The Quad is a mini lateral in the Indo-Pacific which has a potential to be institutionalized yet, the grouping is informal so far. Since its revival in 2017, the foreign ministerial level meetings have happened at an annual level, and since 2021, it has been raised to a summit-level meeting. The only source of the ambitions and working of this grouping can be gained only from the joint statements released after every meeting. This statement speaks about the areas in which the Quad is interested to work and areas of convergence. On terrorism issues the progress is very slow and stable to understand how the Quad navigates through the security issues of Indo-Pacific and its interest in the Indo-Pacific. In 2019, the first foreign ministers meeting was held on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly in New York. In the meeting the leaders discussed collective efforts for the free open and inclusive Indo-Pacific. Counter-terrorism has been a part of the discussion since the first foreign ministers meeting. However, there was no mention of maritime security or other security concerns. In 2020, the foreign minister met for the second time. During this meet Covid-19 remained to be a serious issue of

discussion. In one year there was no new areas of development in security parameters( MEA, GOI, 2019).

The actual traction on security issues begun since the leadership level meeting since 2021. The Quad leaders met for the first time in the Virtual mode in March 2021. In the joint statement. In the statement, they laid out the reason for the partnership being revived work in 2021; it mentioned the security challenges faced by the region as one of the motivating factors behind its resurgence. The leaders also committed to work to advance the security in the region by means of international law and counter threats in the Indo-Pacific and beyond the Indo-Pacific. It is one of the strong statement to say the vision of Quad goes beyond the region. It calls for peaceful resolution of disputes, protecting territorial integrity, enhance democracy. All these three narratives are purely political in nature. It says it looks forward to upholding the region's peace and security and promoting democratic values (MEA, GOI, 2021). The statement encompasses the newer definition of international security, including health, food, and climate security. In conclusion, the statement said it wishes to respond to the historic crisis in the region. The historic crisis in the region is the Korean issue, the Taiwan issue, and Pakistan's illegal occupation of Kashmir. From hesitating to use the word security in 2017 statement to directly advocating for international security, there is an up shift since the first meet. In 2021 the, Quad leaders met for the first time in Washington DC in September 2021. The statement started with acknowledging the regional security issues has become more complex and test countries individually and together. This statement directly relates to China, as India faced a deadly face-off in 2020 with China, the US launched a trade war with China, and Japan China's territorial dispute became furious. It says the region will be undaunted by coercion, a direct reply to the coercive action of China in the South China Sea. During the summit it opened a new cooperation in cyber security arena. In the era of cyber warfare and mounting transnational cyber threats, Quad committed form a working group on cyber security. For the first of kind in 2021, Quad mentioned the Afghanistan security crisis. This event happens one year after the withdrawal of US troops from Afghanistan. It condemned the terror activities and cross-border attacks and held the Taliban to stick to international laws. It also mentions Quad is force for regional peace, stability, security. Next, the statement takes a route to maritime security and claims to champions of global naval laws. It says it meets to respond to the challenges in the rule based order in the East China and South China seas. These are two disputed regions due to Chinese aggression and Quad has directly mentioned that it acknowledges a disturbance to

rule based order in those regions. Looking from a security theorist perspective, Quad is committed to traditional security in the seas, which cannot be hidden (MEA, GOI, 2021).

China is not directly mentioned in the statement. It also looks forward to reaffirm to its commitment to de-nuclearize the Korean peninsula and asks North Korea to abide by international nonproliferation norms. North Korea is a natural ally of China, and Quad is just one step away from China as it has no hesitation to ensure North Korea to be accountable to the action. From the inference it is clear that Quad is committed to work together to work on any provocation on an individual member. The statements from Quad directly correlate with the region's security issues.

In 2022, the Quad leaders met in person in Tokyo, Japan. The joint statement had a separate paragraph titled 'Peace and Stability'. Citing to the previous incidents happened in the seas the statement became more specific compared to last statement. It said it opposes any unilateral action taken by anyone disturbing the region's status quo. It specified areas which it condemns are "militarization of disputed features, the dangerous use of coast guard vessels and maritime militia, and efforts to disrupt other countries' offshore resource exploitation activities". The Chinese were involved in every other issue that the statement mentioned that it wouldn't accept. This shows a clear progress in the style of its working on security. Quad is also a consistent partner of the South-Pacific islands, and it is committed to ensuring the maritime security of the South-Pacific region, as the Chinese are becoming more assertive in economic diplomacy in the South-Pacific. It went strongly against terrorism in Afghanistan and condemned the terror activities that happened in Mumbai on 26/11 and in Pathankot without mentioning Pakistan. It said it is committed to the international commitment to prevent the illegal money laundering used for terror activities. The statement also noted the increased focus on health security and cyber security, which are emerging domains of international security (MEA, GOI, 2022).

In the third in person Quad summit in 2023, new developments in the field of security happened. It condemned the North Korea's launching ballistic missile and asks them to adhere to the norms of the UN security Council resolution. It mentioned the issues and instability in Myanmar and advocated for the peaceful resolution of disputes. Chinese involvement in the Myanmar is worth to be noted here. In matters of terrorism, the Quad pledged to form a new working group on counter-terrorism in 2023. This working group will pave way for organized manner of engaging by Quad in international security matters( MEA, GOI, 2023). In 2024, the May Wilmington Declaration, where four heads of state met, was led by US President Biden.

It mentioned Indo-Pacific is a region where no country dominates and no country is dominated. So far, on security issues, Quad avoided mentioning a state or a country involved in de-stabilizing, only using common words such as parties or members. But in this declaration, it openly mentions 'No country dominates and no country is dominated'. The statement mentioned concerns about specific issues happening in South China sea. It said Quad has serious concerns on "militarization of disputed features, and coercive and intimidating maneuvers". This statement clearly reflects China's aggression in South China Sea. It also cited the Permanent Court of Arbitration's verdict of 2016 between China and the Philippines, over the disputed territorial issues and asked to adhere to the verdict. The verdict is directly associated with Chinese actions in 2024. It also launched a maritime initiative for training in the Indo-Pacific.

As an essential development in defense cooperation among the Quad members, the 2024 summit paved the way for forming the Quad at-sea ship observers mission in 2025, comprising coast guards from four countries. The US Coast Guard, Japan Coast Guard, Australian Border Force, and Indian Coast Guard plan to launch a first-ever Quad-at-Sea Ship Observer Mission in 2025 in the Indo-Pacific to improve interoperability. Through this effort, members of Japan Coast Guard, Australian Border Force, and Indian Coast Guard will spend time on board a US Coast Guard vessel operating in the Indo-Pacific. The Quad intends to continue with further missions in the Indo-Pacific (MEA, GOI, 2024).

These developments since 2017, clearly states that there has been a progressive movement in Quad giving more importance to security domain. Traditional realist scholars argue a grouping can have a security dimension only when militaries associate, or there should be a formal defense alliance similar to NATO, AUKUS, and Warsaw Pact. However, security does not necessarily need to be purely military. Rather, discourse level development also works. In the 2021 statement, the leaders were careful about not posturing Quad to have a security imperatives yet, its concern on North Korea, Afghanistan, and Myanmar shows a dynamic shift. Especially while mentioning the developments in the South China Sea and asking the parties to stick to international norms, it is a strong message to China that the international system will not keep quiet while it can do whatever it wants in its jurisdiction. Quad also focuses on emerging security areas including climate, food, and health security. Counter-terror remains a

top priority for the Quad members, especially for India. Overall Quad has a positive approach on security, as it breaks the stigmas and traditional views of security studies.

**Malabar Exercise**

The term Malabar denotes the Indian coastal state of Kerala which is located in the Western coast Southern India. The people of the Malabar region are eminent seafarers with historical trade and military power legacy. The Malabar Coast was the gateway to Indian influence in the Western Indian ocean. The colonial entry into India also happened in the same region. Honoring the strategic importance of this region, the annual naval exercise between India and USA is named Malabar Exercise. The first edition of this maritime exercise took place in 1992 in the Malabar Coast. This exercise first started as an introductory level naval exercise between Indian Navy and US Navy later grew relevant and became a critical factor in the Quad partnership. The Malabar Exercise is an independent naval exercise not associated with Quad. The exercise begun way before the Quad was formed. However, this exercise plays a crucial role in the security engagement of the Quad members. Quad is not a military partnership but in the way of Malabar exercise the partnership developed a separate offshoot of defense cooperation specific to Indo-Pacific region. Two crucial factors connect Quad with the Malabar exercise. First being geography. Both the Quad and Malabar exercise is associated with the Indo-Pacific region. Second being the membership. The participant countries of Malabar exercise are India, Australia, Japan and the USA, also the Quad members. Though Malabar started as a bilateral exercise with its growing relevance in the Indo-Pacific security architecture, two other Quad members eventually joined. In 2007, a visit of the Japanese Prime Minister, the exercise took a new venture to add three new countries. Japan, Australia, Singapore joined the exercise in 2007 and took place in the Japanese coast of Okinawa. It was the first time the exercise happened outside Indian Ocean, which sites the growth of narrative from Indian Ocean to Indo-Pacific in the Malabar exercise. However post the exercise it received a strong condemnation from the Chinses side. Australian resident in 2007, Kevin Rudd, took a back seat by announcing not to participate in the future. Also it was the same time Quad 1.0 also dissolved. India, in its strategic calculations, decided to keep the exercise as bi-lateral in the future. Growing geo political development led to a churn in Indo-Pacific where new developments happened.

In 2015, Japan joined as permanent member of Malabar exercise despite Chinese concerns. Since, 2015 bi lateral exercise becomes a trilateral exercise with each nation hosting the exercise annually. In 2017 India's aircraft carrier INS Vikramadhithya and USS Nimitz

participated in the exercise in the strategic coast of Guam, which became a breakthrough. In 2020 Australia finally breaks its stigma and participated in the Malabar exercise. Now that Quad and Malabar exercise comes in perfect synergy, both participant nations became same and both groups oriented it towards Indo-Pacific region. Though Australia did not join as a permanent member, it participates in the annual exercise. Australia hosted the 2023 edition of the exercise in the Sydney coast.

Malabar exercise, though not a part of Quad is ,closely associated with Quad. The graph of Quad and Malabar is almost identical. When Quad got shape in 2007 the exercise was a grand success. The fall of Quad1.0 in 2008 eventually led to isolation of Malabar exercise from Quad`s security developments. When Quad revived in 2017 Malabar exercise also revies and grows along with the Quad. But it should not be mis understood that the exercise is a military wing of Quad. The Quad leaders mention that it is purely non-military and not an alliance.

Similarly the exercise is also not structured against any particular nation. Instead, it focuses on strengthening Indo-Pacific security architecture. Quad and Malabar exercises becomes complimentary to each other. There are few short coming with Quad where India's strategic positioning, Australia's balance play restrict to bring a meaningful traditional imperative to Quad, yet the Malabar exercise fills the void. The exercise helps Quad to achieve its purpose outside the structure. In flexibility of Quad allows to happen such exercises without affecting its credibility. In these areas the intertest based partnership evolves in security strategies ensuring safe Indo-Pacific. The exercise complements the Quad's free open and inclusive Indo-Pacific values. Apart from Malabar exercise, exercise pitch black conducted by the royal Australian air force is similar to the previous. It is a multilateral air exercise with 20 participant nation. All four Quad members are participant of the pitch black exercise. Through such defense exercises, the security development of the Indo-Pacific region is steady and develops in an orderly manner. The Quad has ensured crucially that it takes its security developments in a constant, structured manner without antagonizing or posing against a specific nation. Instead of building security imperatives focusing on development and emerging security issues, Quad ensures in its best possible ways to build an order in Indo-Pacific that is resilient, safe and secure (Sayanthan Haldar, 2020).

## Chapter III

## Individual Member states take on Quad's Institutionalization

### Australia

Australia's relationship with Quad is time-tested and wavering in nature. Though Australia showed eagerness during the formation in 2004, it played a pivotal role during the Quad 1.0 dissolution in 2008. In 2008, the Prime Minister of Australia, Kevin Rudd, openly declared their disapproval of the future of Quad and withdrew from it. This event led to a complete stalemate in the evolution of Quad. The reason for this happenings is primarily associated with Kevin Rudd, as he took a pro-Chinese stand. Rudd associated Quad as an anti China partnership instead of a development partnership envisioned by other leaders. In 2008, in the aftermath of these events, Kevin Rudd visited China and held meetings with the Chinese premier. While the Quad partners were bracing themselves to tackle Chinese acquisitions, Rudd immediately changed his partnership towards China (Kate Sullivan de Estrada, 2018). But Australia, in 2021, went on an open military alliance with the USA and UK to form AUKUS. Under the AUKUS deal UK and USA will deliver nuclear powered submarines to Australia as a primary deterrent against Chinese assertiveness in the Indo-Pacific region (House of Lords Library, 2021). The credit for the revival of Australia's drifting back into the process of Quad goes to former Prime Minister Tony Abbott. Mr. Abbott believes in India's pivotal role in the Indo-Pacific security. During his tenure, he improved the bi-lateral relations with India and other Quad members, which positively contributed to the Growth of Quad.

Australia's position on Institutionalization of Quad will be associated with three factors. The first factor is growing strategic convergence with the Indo-Pacific members. Despite Australia being a geo-strategic position between the Indian Ocean and the Pacific Ocean, it has distanced itself from the Indo-Pacific narrative and sticks to the Pacific or Oceania position. However, the reluctance came down over time as Indo-Pacific, especially India's role in the region, started getting consolidated. Growth of ASEAN economies is also a reason. Australia felt left out of the regional politics of the Indo-Pacific, and when it decides to play an active role in it, Quad will be the best way to engage in the Indo-Pacific for Australia. Second factor is its allies. Australia is the only country in Quad to have a direct military alliance with the USA. This military alliance is essential for Australia to have a strategic defense ally to prevent its interest while Indian Ocean militarization is rampantly increasing. The AUKUS pact also plays a critical role in Australia's role in Quad. Australia and the US have come into a direct military

agreement under which the US will supply a Virgina class submarine to Australia. Australia has pledged to invest in the shipbuilding industry of the US. Australia is now dependent on US for its security. The US will now have direct ascendance over Australia's strategic calculation. If the US wants to institutionalize Quad it will lobby Australia to support its cause. However the nature of Quad is democratic and since it is not in single member states influence it is un likely to happen.

There is another strategic angle involved. Since Australia is already in a defense pact, the cost-benefit of Australia advocating to institutionalize Quad will be under question. They won't need one more institution as they are already part of another Indo-Pacific-oriented defense pact. Third and most crucial factor influencing Australia's decision will be China. Australia and China have strong trade relations. Since Kevin Rudd's pro-China policy, the relations were bullish. However, as time changed and China's aggression post-2014, Australia reigned and decoupled with China strategically and politically. Trade is still tangled. The relations are aggravated since AUKUS pacts. Bi-lateral relations hit the worst phase when Australia asked for an independent inquiry to find the origin of Covid- 19 SARS virus alleging China's role in the Pandemic. Since the event trade war begun between Australia and China since 2021. Both nations imposed reciprocal tariffs and increased custom duty. Australia fears its trade deficit with China will be weaponized against them. On 25 February 2025, for the first time in the Indo-Pacific the Chinese PLA Navy conducted live firing exercises in the Tasman sea, just 300 Nautical miles the from Australian Coast. This led to re-routing of over 40 commercial aircraft flying in Australian airspace. This events led to a stern response from Australia and New Zealand. Australia convened an immediate parliamentary meeting, and the Australian foreign minister Penny Wong met the Chinese counterpart to raise her concerns. Such events had never happened before and its shows how the Chinese PLA is moving its aggression from its near coast to far as Australia. In this circumstance, Australia will consider Quad the best option to deter China (Patrick Gerard Buchan and Benjamin Rimland, 2020).

Since the nature of Quad is very adoptable without creating international repercussions, Australia in the future would advocate for a security angle for the Quad, which will be closely associated with the institutionalization process. Australia's inclusion in the Malabar exercise in 2020 is a strong message that Australia will be open to new steps to build Quad to the next level. Leadership plays a crucial role in institutionalization process. The previous Australian leadership was skeptical about the Quad process. PM Tony Abbott brought a new momentum in Quad. China's tariffs will play a crucial role. The current prime minister Antony Albanese

aligns with the interest of Quad. Australia will also get to play a middle power role in Quad by which it can secure its regional interest. Their strategic outlook is similar to India's strategic autonomy. Quad will help to deter Chinese aggression and if China were to become directly aggressive and bully Australia tit will bring down all the hesitation for an open call for institutionalization. Trade will remain the only concern for Australia since China is one of its significant trade partners. But Australia is now looking for diversified trade partners such as India and West Asia to explore new markets to increase their exports. If the trade coupling happens successfully, it will be advantageous for Australia to secure its interest by institutionalizing ( Kate Sullivan de Estrada,2018).

**Japan**

The most instrumental role played in the establishment of Quad and giving it a shape and purpose is credited to the former prime minister of Japan, Shin Zo Abe. Japan is one of the most involved and enthusiastic partner in Quad. 2007 speech of PM Shin Zo Abe in the Indian parliament is the founding stone of Quad. His idea of the confluence of two seas and the emergence of the waters as one of freedom and prosperity not only help to structure Quad but also gave a definition and value for the entire Indo-Pacific narrative( Shin Zo Abe,2007). Next to India, Japan is at the closest proximity with China and has a complicated history with China. China's assertiveness in the Taiwan Strait, Hong Kong, and close relations with North Korea paves the way for de stability in East Asia. Japan has direct concerns and territorial dispute with China. These factors makes Quad a pivotal strategic card for Japan. Since post-pandemic, Japan is rearming itself, moving away from the US deterrence shield. It has pledged to spend 59 billion USD on defense for 2025. It seeks for a diversified defense partners such as India, South Korea, and Australia to strengthen its security framework. Quad will remain to be a top priority in their security strategy. Japan is expecting Quad to take covert security angle in order to better deterrence to China (Kei Koga, 2023).

The factor that makes Japan rely upon Quad in Indo-Pacific security architecture is not primarily  form a defense alliance but to help ensure a rule-based order. India and Japan are two Indo-Pacific nations near China. These two nations are well aware of the need for rule-based order in the Indo-Pacific and are very confident on Quad. India and Japan individually cannot ensure the rule-based inclusive order in the Indo-Pacific, but using Quad, they can provide rule-based order effectively. Understanding the strategic relevance of Quad, PM Shin Zo Abe initiated diplomatic traction in 2007 to institutionalize Quad. This step by Abe is the

first direct step taken for institutionalization. However, the proposal failed to gain traction due to difference of interest and the past international order. Immediately in 2008, Australia withdrew from Quad.

In 2012, Abe again tried to create a discourse titled 'Asia's strategic and security diamond', which he directly referred to as Quad. In 2016 he launched Japan's Indo-Pacific strategic vision statement. It called for an free, open, inclusive Indo-Pacific. This vision came amidst the protest in Kong Kong and alleged Chinese suppression. In that vision, he prioritized Quad as a primary institutional framework to achieve the Japanese vision of its neighbourhood.

Three factors will play a crucial role in Japan's decision towards institutionalizing Quad. First is rule-based order of the region and Japan's economy. Japan is the biggest economy in Asia after China. Japan has good trade relations with South Asia, ASEAN states, South Pacific and vis a vis USA. To ensure a flourishing trade predominantly maritime trade rule-based order becomes a crucial factor. Other regional frameworks in the Indo-Pacific include IORA, ASEAN, South-Pacific forum, and Mekong cooperation. Japan is not a part of this any regional frameworks of Indo-Pacific. This factor makes Japan rely only upon Quad for taking multi-lateral and consensus efforts to ensure rule-based order in the Indo-Pacific. Japan will push for institutionalizing Quad in this term to amplify its regional voice (Kei Koga, 2023).

Second factor being China. Japan-China bi-lateral relations are seeing a dip in recent decades due to territorial disputes, trade irregularities, hedging by China, and threatening actions in Taiwan. The Senkaku island dispute remains a top territorial dispute between the East Asian rivals. Chinese is also accused of violating Japan's EEZ and involving in illegal activities in the continental shelf of Japan. Multiple interruption of Japan's airspace by the Chinese PLA Air Force is also a deep concern. Growing aggressive activities of China will in evidently push Japan for adding more security element to Quad. Japan is open to making Quad a defense partnership to create a democratic rule based deterrence against China. The third factor is that Japan will get a strategic advantage from the Institutionalization process. Compared to India, Japan is open for direct actions against China. Since there is an absence of a security cooperation agreement with legal force in the Indo-Pacific, Japan is open to creating a defense community in the Indo-Pacific positioned against China. Japan intends to build a shared consensus among Quad members and create legal mechanisms and commitments. Japan is aware that they cannot stay away from considerable power politics of the region and cannot bat alone for its interest. Like-minded partners are needed to form a shared commitment and

consensus. For that cause institutionalizing Quad becomes pivotal for Japan. Japan believes it can reshape the regional order through Quad and has invested a lot of diplomatic effort in it. Japan has limited strategic partners in the region (Martina Gomez, 2024).

While the US has been an ally since 1953, India and Australia are potential partners in building new relations. The reasons are that they are vibrant democracies, emerging markets, established defense sectors, and, most importantly, they have a common aggressor. These factors push Japan to rely on Quad over other mechanisms. Out of four Quad nations, Japan has directly advocated institutionalizing it. Not just Institutionalizing, Japan wants Quad to have more security dimensions. This includes joint commitments, joint patrol and exercise and more defense cooperation. Noting the issues with Quad taking a defense angle, Japan is now focusing on improving bi-lateral defense relations with Quad members separately. For Japan, Quad is predominantly used for defense and security. It will keep pushing the group for the institutionalization process, and if Quad were to open a secretariat in the future, Japan would be happy to open the doors of Tokyo without hesitation ( Diplomatic Bluebook, Japan, 2017).

**India**

India is arguably the most crucial player in the Quad. What makes India ahead of other players in Quad is that the Quad embodies India's change in its foreign policy from nonalignment to multi-alignment. Quad has broken all of India's strategic hesitations and gave a new impetus for its foreign policy. India considers Quad as its primary way of engagement in the Indo-Pacific. Along with PM Abe, another person who played a pivotal role in establishing Quad is the foreign minister of India Dr. S Jaishankar. His contributions to Quad has been valuable since his days as the foreign secretary of India. India's position and definition of Quad give legitimacy to Quad. Without India scholars will agree Quad as the Asian NATO, critiqued by China. But India's posture in Quad ensures its will never become an Asian NATO. In the 2018 Shangri La Dialogue, the Prime Minister of India, Mr. Narendra Modi spoke about the role of the Indo-Pacific in the future world order and advocated for a rule-based order. India has taken multiple policy level actions and schemes to engage Indo-Pacific. It has launched project 'Mausam' a cultural outreach program, and a SAGAR initiative for a resilient supply chain through Indo-Pacific. India's maritime fusion center for IOR in Gurgaon is a hub for information and intelligence in the Indian Ocean region. All these activities of India are complementary to Quad's vision of the Indo-Pacific ( Samir Saran, 2024).

India's position in the Institutionalization of Quad is nuanced and delicate in nature. India has a rich legacy of strategic autonomy as a key driver of foreign policy. It ensures it always stands by people-centric values and interests over another nation's interest. Despite many pressures during the Cold War period, it ensured not to participate in any defense alliance. India has defense partnership but not defense allies. Its previous wars and complications taught the reality of self-help when it comes to defense, and it has ensured they are ready alone any time for a crisis. However, India has also decided to go on a partnership if it firmly ensures it will not affect its strategic autonomy. For instance in 1971, India signed friendship treaty with the then USSR. The treaty ensured to hedge the US-China-Pakistan axis strategically. Yet the treaty never made India a subjugate, subordinate, or liable to USSR. India is always open to interest-based partnerships, and Quad is also an interest-based partnership. Gaining lessons from its previous episodes, India will ensure that Quad will not affect its strategic autonomy. India carefully reshaped the purpose, definition, and working of Quad. Quad is one partnership where the US is present but not solely dominant. Other Quad members are also aware the this partnership will have no momentum without India and India invariably has a strategic advantage in Quad (Priyanka Mallik, 2024).

Three factors affect India's momentum on the Institutionalization of Quad. First is strategic doctrines of Indian Foreign Policy. India foreign policy institutions and policies are structured and organized based on its principles of its foreign policy. India's policy decisions in international affairs are not driven by the ongoing momentum or pressure. The decision is always taken with a far-sighted approach and what impacts it will make on the long term. India's reaction to the deadly attack in Mumbai on 26/11 is an example. It ensures the policies aligns with its values, determinants, and principles. But in recent decades, there has been a profound shift in its principles. India openly agreed that non-alignment is no longer a policy and is shifting towards multi-alignment. It is taking economic and soft power diplomacy into its hands for greater outreach. Nations that remain silent on international affairs which don't concern their interests are now actively engaging in every crucial international decision-making process. India is there everywhere. It has come up with visionary ambitions such as one earth, one family, one future principle. India intends to bring the world one step closer to each other. PM Modi's statement that India is not avoiding taking a side, it is taking a side and the side is peace. They are using a pointed alignment strategy for specific national interests. The NSA of India argues that there is a shift from defensive to defensive offense approaches. This change of character and re-defining of India's foreign policy positively contribute to Quad's

Institutionalization. If India feels that institutionalization is the need of the hour for the best of the Indo-Pacific, it will ensure that the institutionalization process happens without affecting its strategic autonomy. It will ensure Quad will be democratic and nations will share equal space and voice ( Ashok Sajjanhar, 2020).

Second factor will be China. While China and its allies try to portray Quad as an anti-China alliance or an Asian NATO, India sternly stays away from such acquisitions. It has mentioned that it not pointed against any nation. Quad is a development partnership working for the rule based order of the Indo-Pacific. However, the disruptor of rule-based order is China. India is sure that Quad is not anti-China, but if China disrupts the free open order of Indo-Pacific, it will not stay quiet from making China liable for its actions. The situation in borders plays a crucial role. Scholars believe that any unilateral attempt by India will aggravate the border situation ( Harsh V Pant, 2021).

Since October 2024, Indian officers have been working by having multiple rounds of consultation with China and successfully bringing a consensus in the borders. Yet it is only temporary and China is known for breaking its promise. Right now, India doesn't want to give China a reason to aggravate the situation in the borders. Still India will have Quad as card on China. When the deadly Galwan clashes happened the following year the Quad leaders met in person. The Joint Statements has seen a significant uptick in getting closer to China. Due to this reason India is handling institutionalization process carefully. When China takes assertive actions in the Indo-Pacific in the future, India will not hesitate to level up the process despite the border situation. China is also aware of the development happening in the Indo-Pacific region led by Quad. It challenges its interest in the South and East China Sea and blocks economic assertiveness. So for Quad worked as an effective deterrent on China ( Harsh V Pant, 2021).

Third factor is institutionalization and security commitment. India is not a defense ally with any state. The main feature behind institutionalization will be the security and defense arrangements in an organized manner. India is the net security partner in the Indian ocean region and has a good defense partnership with the Indo-Pacific. India doesn't want the IOR to be weaponized extensively. The security factor also puts a restriction on Quad as a defense bloc. India wants a diversified Quad not as a bloc. But if the Chinese aggression increases in the future, it will pave the way for more synergy among the defense partners for extensive deterrence. India will take the institutionalization process similar to BRICS, IORA. It will

ensure it has more development partnership organizations and provide security. Security through development will be the approach of India in Quad's security angle. However, the US and Japan push for a direct security engagement, and Australia will support the US's choice. Within Quad security arrangements of a formal Quad, India must navigate carefully. India should strongly look into the strategic advantages India will get by giving more security impetus to institutional framework. In current political developments in the Indo-Pacific, India will have a low profile in security to avoid a Chinese response. Yet India will be open to a security partnership for effective deterrence when the need comes (Priyanka Mallik,2024).

**United States of America**

In May 2018, The United States Navy's Pacific Command was renamed Indo-Pacific Command. Soon after the inauguration of US President Joseph Biden in 2020, his Secretary of Defense Lloyd Austin made his first state visit to ASEAN countries to improve the bilateral ties, especially defense ties. The 2022 US national security strategy mentioned that 'Beijing's vision would move us away from the universal values that have sustained so much of the world's progress over the past 75 years'. It also highlighted China as a primary concern for the international order despite the Russian invasion of Ukraine. US also launched its Indo-Pacific strategy document in 2022. In 2024, marking the second anniversary of the document the secretary of state Antony Blinken released another document. In it he mentioned that China is assertive abroad and are involved in huma right violations within and outside its territory. It said China is disrupting the international order by disrespecting the international law. Antony Blinken also mentioned India as the regional leader of Indo-Pacific and pointed the white house interest to cooperate more with India aligning with the interest of Quad. President Trump initiated a trade war with China in his first term, which the Biden government continued to follow. In 2022-2023 tensions along Taiwan strait sprung up leading to Chinese and US carrier groups facing each other. Returning to power the Trump government shows more assertiveness towards China and increased import tariffs on critical areas. The US banned critical technology, especially semi conducted export to China, to disrupt its emerging technology industry. These actions shows US considers China as its primary rival in the 21st century and a immediate threat factor. US's position is entirely anti China compared to other member states. The idea behind solidifying the Indo-Pacific narrative by the US is to strengthen its position and influence across the Pacific Ocean to the Indian Ocean and South China Sea by linking those seas. The US has a naval base in the Diego Garcia islands in the Indian Ocean, which the UK

shares. US considers Diego Garcia a crucial base to press China in the IOR (Ashok Sajjanhar, 2020).

The primary driving factor of US motivation in institutionalizing Quad will be the China factor. The US has taken various steps to strengthen its position in the Indo-Pacific over the decades. First, the relationship status with India must be increased. As India's relationship with the US has been embroiled in its recent developments since 2008, 123 agreement is worth noting. India-US defense partnership also comes together, with China being a common denominator. US is aware it needs India for any legible action in the Indo-Pacific and is looking to deepen the cooperation focused on China. Secondly it tries to bring more defence presence in the region. The US signed the AUKUS pact in 2021 and pushed NATO beyond Trans-Atlantic perimeter into Indo-Pacific. Japan and South Korea established partnership with NATO. In that context US will see Quad from a security angle in Indo-Pacific. In recent years, the US initiated a patrol and surveillance program in the South China Sea. It cooperates with the Philippines to track Chinese developments in the South China sea.US invited Quad members to participate in the program (Kevin Rudd, 2021).

While Japan and Australia joined hands with the US, India rejected the request. US is determined to add more security element into Quad and wishes to project Quad as a security partnership. But Quad is unlike other partnership of US where they have direct ascendance and influence. But Quad is a democratic partnership of four nations where all countries have equal voice and share. India and Australia don't want to give overt security impetus to Quad given its bilateral relations with China. The US is so desperate to make Quad a security partnership. Taking a step ahead, US Secretary of State Antony Blinken announced the establishment of a new mini lateral 'squad'. The squad comprises Australia, Japan, the USA, and the Philippines. Squad partnership is crafted as a direct defense partnership with defense and security commitments amongst each other. The US is willing to use different opportunities and chances to develop an anti-China lobby in the Indo-Pacific region.

While Quad has more development grouping such as infrastructure and critical technology grouping, US is concerned only about the future security impetus it will get. US is hopeful of Quad's growth and is projected towards an institutionalization process. India and Australia are looking for a soft institution where Quad will have development as a main agenda. US wants an arduous institutionalization process. It intends to bring the Quad members under its deterrent

umbrella and sign security commitment among the member states. This ambition of US follows the geographical advantage of US vis a vis China ( John G Murphy, 2025).

The question of institutionalization will be answered only when a joint consensus is created among Quad members. Each nation have its strategic priorities, and institutionalization will happen only when it reaches the top priorities of all the Quad members. One factor common to all nation is China. Though it started as a development partnership Quad proved to be an effective deterrent against China. Comparing the growth of Quad directly relates to increasing Chinese aggression in the region. From the revival to foreign minister level meetings to summit level upgradation, concerns on the South China Sea every development is a reaction to Chinese aggression. The Galwan Valley clash, the US-China trade war, and the Senkaku island disputes are pivotal events. China over the past decades from similar organizations to Quad and has successfully institutionalized ( Ashok Sajjanhar, 2020). The Shanghai Five, which began as a development partnership, later became the Shanghai Cooperation Organization. China also initiated other processes, such as RCEP and BRI. China calls RCEP an economic assistance program yet pushes coercive economic diplomacy in such means. These factors push Quad towards getting a more institutionalized structure than the current being. Since 2017 there has been a convergence among the member states in multiple areas of interest especially security. The Quad partners know they cannot fight for rule based order alone in the Indo-Pacific for free and open order. Convergence in terms of security cooperation will be essential to deter potential future aggression. The Quad countries are working in security outside the Quad framework. The Malabar exercise, exercise Pitch black, RIMPAC, Dharma Guardian. Treaties such as LEMOA, COMCASA between India and USA, treaty of cooperation and security between USA and Japan, Australia Japan Reciprocal Access Agreement, ANZUS treaty involving US, Australia, Japan will play a pivotal role in Indo-Pacific security architecture aligning with the interest of Quad. Member states are clear that Quad is not a bloc rather a partnership. India and the USA have already mentioned their interest in diversifying Quad and bringing more member states aligning with the values of the Indo-Pacific. The Quad plus narrative has already unfolded ( Jagganath Panda, 2022).

New members who will strengthen the existing framework will be Vietnam, South Korea, and New Zealand. Adding more members will be a crucial step towards institutionalization. With four members the Quad can work with the existing mechanism. However, when more members join, the interest expands, and partnerships and responsibilities diversify. Liberal institutionalism scholars argue that diversification of a Mini lateral is a step towards

institutionalization. ASEAN is the best example. ASEAN first began with only five members in 1963. Its first leadership summit was held only in 1971. Adding more Southeast Asian members led to an institutional framework. Quad is also following a similar pattern of the mini-lateral institutionalization process, and this process can fuelled by the Chinese activities in the Indo-Pacific( Jagganath Panda, 2022).

## Chapter IV

## Impacts of Institutionalization process in Indo-Pacific security architecture and challenges

### Cooperative security Governance

The difference that Quad will make in the security architecture of the Indo-Pacific region with and without being institutionalized is mainly quantifiable. Firstly, the international peace and security institutions, especially the United Nations Security Council, have failed to keep their promises. International conflicts have now become extra-regional, where one conflict is influenced and decided by states in another region. For example, the Ukraine-Russia war that has been happening since 2022 is primarily orchestrated by the US. In the Israel-Hamas war, the US plays an instrumental role in deciding the course of the nature of the conflict. Since the disputes have become fluid and international peace and security institutions have failed, countries have been forced to create regional defense and deterrence institutions for peace and security. Europe has established NATO as the most successful collective defense institution. In Southeast Asia, ASEAN has emerged as a potent force with security commitments and close security partnerships to deter external threats. In regions where such institutional mechanisms have failed, conflict can easily protrude. West Asia and Africa are examples. Since conflicts are also taking a maritime shift, a new emphasis on maritime-oriented security establishments becomes crucial. The Indo-Pacific region is diverse, vast, and economically vibrant. The 21st-century political economy is shifting towards the Indo-Pacific, and security issues are emerging along with growth ( Kate Sullivan de Estrada, 2023).

When the need for a security institution for the Indo-Pacific is clear Quad decides how effective it will be. The security institutions are wide ranging in nature from NATO a pure collective defense mechanism to Quad a cooperative partnership with security emphasis. The need for what extent it should be decided upon the existing system. Chinese assertiveness and aggression are apparent and undoubted. Its artificial island build ups in South China sea, threatening the neighbours such as Japan, Philippines, Vietnam is evident. Their coercive economic diplomacy and weaponization of trade is emerging threats of international security. Despite being aggressive the way China portrays to be a responsible player and victimizing itself that the system is against them is evident. Given the developments, we cannot expect China to follow a rule-based order in the Indo-Pacific. When Quad becomes an institutionalized grouping, it can go for a rule-based cooperative security governance. Unlike NATO, where

security is restricted to its member state in a cooperative security governance factor, security will not be focused on specific nations but on a region as a whole. A cooperative security governance mechanism with multiple Indo-Pacific nations involved, various Indo-Pacific organizations such as ASEAN, IORA, and South Pacific organizations engaged under the leadership of Quad, can establish a safe and secure conduct of international affairs in the Indo-Pacific. It does not necessarily to be even defense forces involved in nature. It can even emerge as a narrative as Indo-Pacific cooperative security mechanism. Quad is a unique partnership. It is bound by democratic values, accommodating extra-regional members, and focused on regional growth and development. Most importantly, Quad is the most democratic partnership with equal roles for all members. In this situation, Quad has all the legitimacy and credibility to invoke security parameters (Gorana Grgic, 2024).

When institutionalized, it forms a network of nations with cooperative security working mechanisms, which will help at the discourse level to build the Indo-Pacific regional security. Only Quad can do it because other organizations have geographical limitations or work in the interest of a specific nation. The institutionalization of Quad will leverage the powers and responsibilities of the United Nations charter. The UN asks for more regional mechanisms to be involved in peace and security, aiding the ambitions of Quad. There is a shift from investments from China to emerging economies for resilient supply chains and seamless production. Indo-Pacific nations such as India and Vietnam have lots of potential to grab the opportunities that will help the growth of individuals. It will affect domestic-level growth, such as poverty, health, and education. For that shift to happen, investors should have confidence in the region. When Quad is institutionalized and gets security promises to the regional members, companies will gain confidence to invest more ( Kate Sullivan de Estrada, 2024).

Institutionalization is crucial to uphold the open, free, inclusive and rule based order in the Indo-Pacific. Because these are still value-based level and values of freeness and openness change from one nation to another. If it's only in value level, its magnitude changes from time to time based on the individual interest. These values will be defined, structured, and specific when they get an institutionalized structure. When the values become vision, it will ensure a strong deterrence to prevent any actor from violating these visions. The current international system is fluid and volatile, where one conflict moves from one region to another quickly. The growing North Korea and Russia nexus forms a network on nation, from Iran, Russia, China, North Korea, Sahel region of Africa and the domino effect is likely to increase in future. In this context, institutionalization can be taken as a defensive approach to brace up for any such

situation in the coming future. Quad can effectively play a good office role in resolving many conflicts. But to uphold its good office posture it needs an institutional character ( Sayanthan Haldar, 2024).

**Deter China`s aggression.**

In the 2024 APEC summit, the president of China said that China`s development is inseparable from the Asia Pacific. While the Indo-Pacific narrative is widely accepted worldwide, China still refrains from terming the region Indo-Pacific and continues with Asia-Pacific. China also ensures that India is not part of the Asian narrative and China as the only embodiment of Asia. China is apprehensive about Quad that if Quad is to become stronger in the future, it will challenge China`s hegemonic interest in the region. What makes it more challenging and unacceptable for China with Quad is India`s position in the region via Quad. Since its creation, China has ensured that India will surpass China in any way and does not want the regional order favouring India and India`s influence on its neighbors. India`s strong natural partnership with Russia, and growing issues based partnership with US concerns China`s hegemonic interest in Indo-Pacific. For this reason China deliberately blocks India`s entry into security council`s permanent membership and membership into NSG. However to the international media China portrays to be a partner with India and it is India which is violating the international law. Quad will ensure India`s strong regional presence in such rival political competition. Indian foreign policy network thinks any attempt to institutionalize Quad will apprehend China, and India will face a significant blow to the process. But India`s process in institutionalization is itself a strategic win for India. As its Asian NATO narrative couldn't be sold in the international market with India`s presence and its strong position to not join any military alliance, it has recently changed its position. It criticized Quad as a US way to control the region and prevent China`s growth and kept protesting for any development in Quad. While the Quad members have clarified that it is a democratic development partnership, China is in agony that development in the Indo-Pacific is not happening in the red banner. China has a hidden agenda for every development and assistance program. Sri Lanka and Maldives are the best examples. However in Quad`s case its non committed development partnership. This will shift away the traction from China ( Mohammad Shoaib Pervez, 2023).

The institutionalization process will be a direct blow to China. At the same time, it has institutional frameworks such as RCEP and BRI. Quad already has multiple working groups, such as the infrastructure development working group and health security working group.

Institutionalization will deepen the development partnership. Quad envisions security through a development program. By developing a nation's comprehensive nation, power increases through which it can effectively deter growing threats. It will also help in capacity building to combat emerging threats such as cyber warfare and artificial Intelligence warfare. Security will not be the direct product of the institutionalization process but a by-product. First, it will block the Chinese investment trap; next, it will help the Indo-Pacific to grow and become closer. A diversified Quad will be a democratic platform that will amplify the smaller nation's voices to uphold its interest. Together, it will result in overall security development of the region. The institutionalization process is crucial in combating Chinese growth in the area, will positively impact Indo-Pacific security architecture. ( Tayyaba Jeffery, 2023)

**Free, Open, Inclusive and Rule-Based Order**

Free, Open, Inclusive, and Rule-based order are the cornerstone values of the Quad. Institutionalization will help ensure this order in the Indo-Pacific in an effective and long-lasting manner. These values denote an Indo-Pacific without any traditional or non-traditional security issues, equitable usage of the ocean for maximum benefits, open for all members of the international system, which ensures the free movement of goods across critical sea lines of trade and communication, and most importantly, regional not under the influence of any single member. Quad as a mini lateral have already achieved institutionalization to a certain degree. The traditional school of thought on institutionalism often takes the character of the UN as an ideal institution. It should have a secretariat, presidency, charter and other traditional means. But in the 21st century, there is a shift from multi-lateral to mini laterals. Mini laterals are group of nations comprising three to nine nation. These are issue-based partnership that comes together based on a common consensus. These mini laterals are hybrid and flexible in nature. These are called proto alliance when it comes to defense partnerships (Australian Government, Department of Foreign Affairs, 2023).

NATO began as a proto-alliance via the Brussels defense treaty of 1948, and later got institutionalized. These mini laterals are often a nascent stage of institutionalized multi-lateral formation. The Quad also follows the exact track of the process of others. In mini laterals, the extent of institutionalization is not scaled by the traditional physical elements; instead, it focuses on working. Quad already has two essential aspects of an institution. First is the summit-level meeting since 2021. The leaders have pledged to meet annually a primary characteristic of Quad (MEA, GOI, 2021).

A second important factor is working through joint working groups. These are issue-based working groups with a formal organization. There are 3 working groups in Quad with direct security impetus. First is the maritime security working group, which focuses on issues of marine security, especially the developments in the South and East China Sea. Second, is the counter-terror working group with a specific focus on maritime terrorism, and the third is the cyber security working group to track down emerging security issues in cyberspace. These factors are evident that mini laterals will have quasi institutional structure unlike the traditional ones. However, security commitments are crucial to the institutional structure to the fullest. By cooperative security partnership means in bi lateral level and through intelligence and data sharing among Quad members the security aspect is gaining traction slowly aligning with the values of free, open and inclusive. These values will become principles when Quad is formally institutionalized, and while they become principles to achieve its commitments and responsibilities in a codified manner, they will emerge from member states. It will also include security characteristics that will further help strengthen the Indo-Pacific architecture. While the members are already working for upholding the values, institutional factors will add steel frames to the structure, which will prevent the collapse of the Indo-Pacific security framework despite any shock and trouble( MEA, GOI, 2023).

**Deter non-traditional security challenges**.

The number of commercial ships that used the Suez Canal for its transit between the Indian Ocean to the Mediterranean has reduced from 23,000 ships to 13,000 boats in 2024. The reason is primarily attributed to the Rea sea crisis due to the Houth rebels. Ships are forced to take a longer route through the Cape of Good Hope, leading to delays and increases of cost in the supply chain. This example shows how important it is to protect the supply chains in the Indo-Pacific and how vulnerable they are. In November 2024 four under sea cables AAE-1, Seacom, EIG, and TGN were severed by un known players. These undersea cables are the nervous system of international networks. The non-traditional security issues are not only restricted to terrorist activities against traditional defense forces but also to supply chain and communication and keep evolving. Climate change is also a serious issue in the Indo-Pacific. The region is home to niche coral reefs, biodiversity hot spots, mangrove shores, aquatic rich shoals ( Sreeparna Banarjee, 2022).

Maldives and South Pacific nations are likely to be the worst victim of the climate change and both are in the Indo-Pacific region. The Indo-Pacific is also home to developing economies

fighting poverty, hunger, and health crisis. Non-traditional security aspects in the Indo-Pacific are also crucially important. Institutionalization process will diversify its security impetus and brings all these non-traditional security issues into serious consideration. Quad has already formed a working group on climate change and counter-terrorism. However, a comprehensive approach is required. Non-traditional issues are unlike traditional security issues, which can be solved by negotiation and at the table. It needs on ground practical, long-term actions. It cannot be done only by a small group of countries, even if they can't achieve it. It needs a more significant synergy, joint actions, high funding from many nations. A coordinated effort is crucial. Such high-impact action cannot be taken without an institutionalized framework. Only if there is an institutional factor can it pool funding, set a target, assign a working group, implement, and check its effectiveness. All four Quad members are committed partners in counter-terror and climate change actions. They have high priorities at the individual level. When institutionalized, this partnership can inspire other actors and players to work on non-traditional security issues. While these issues are to take over the traditional issues in the future, a comprehensive approach is required. Quad as a mini lateral organization can do it effectively. While diversifying its membership to include more member states, it can effectively deal with multi-dimensional security issues innovatively by incorporating traditional knowledge. No region can ignore the mounting issues in non-traditional paradigms, especially terror outfits, and how they evolve and equip themselves with modern technologies. An institutionalized Quad will be an effective deterrent ( Pratnashree Basu, 2022).

**Challenges in institutionalization**

**ASEAN Dilemma**

Quad since its inception has reiterated to the ASEAN centrality of the Indo-Pacific region. While the role of Quad partners is important in the Indo-Pacific, the area would be complete with the ASEAN. ASEAN is the most influential organization and also one of the most successful regional organizations. Their success is due to the careful balance of power between the West and China. West is an important trade partner, whereas China is a cultural and geo-strategic partner. ASEAN has not vehemently opposed or taken an opposite stand to Quad, yet carefully observes every development of the Quad. ASEAN Indo-Pacific vision was launched in the year 2018. Its vision and values are similar to Quad's but more ASEAN-centric. ASEAN is careful not to leverage its strategic dominance to Quad (Kei Koga, 2023). Quad partners have strong relationship with ASEAN especially India. To not hedge ASEAN in Indo-Pacific in

every statement, it supports ASEAN's centrality to Indo-Pacific and its willingness to work in close cooperation with the ASEAN. Yet, the Southeast Asian counterparts have not shown as much enthusiasm for Quad. Yet there is a sizeable shift in its approach due to China. China`s activities concern the Philippines, Vietnam, and Malaysia, especially in maritime space. It feels Quad is fulfilling its role and expectations with China, so they don't need to antagonize them. The Philippines have signed a military partnership, and through the Philippines, the US will try to lobby ASEAN to take a hard stand vis a vis China ( Gurjith Singh, 2024). However, ASEAN will not wish to share another institution in the Indo-Pacific region, which will play an assertive role. It ensures that in institutional framework ASEAN should lead others. There won't be a direct blockade or concern from ASEAN yet; it will dent the strategic relation with the USA, which will allow the Chinese to get closer with ASEAN. Quad will be forced to navigate its institutionalization process without apprehending ASEAN. Quad leaders must assure ASEAN that it won't leverage their strategic domination but rather become a strategic partnership. If Quad were to expand, more ASEAN members are expected to join. Vietnam is already in the Quad plus dialogue and the Philippines is likely to take part from the East Asian side of the Quad along with Japan ( Don Mclain Gill, 2024) .

**Arms Race in Indo-Pacific**

The Indo-Pacific region is witnessing mounting arms development across the spectrum. Nations are spending extensively on naval capabilities for effective deterrence. China's naval ambition to outplay the US Navy will have a direct impact on the security architecture of the Indo-Pacific. The institutionalization process has a chance of catalyzing arms race. Smaller n ations such as Pakistan and Bangladesh are increasing their defense spending. Pakistan procures eight hangor class submarines from China, and Bangladesh intends to expand its naval fleet in the Bay of Bengal. ( Daniel Hurst, 2022)

Growing Chinese assertion in Western Indo-Pacific is concerning. Their activities in Djibouti is increasing its assertiveness. China also intends to build a secret naval base on the Cambodian coast and establish a network of Chinese naval capabilities. China has shown its concerns on Quad that it is trying to de-stabilize peace and order in the region. Its famous Asian NATO narrative portrays Quad as a US-led alliance. But Chinese actions are forcing the democratic nations in the region to brace up themselves. From India to ASEAN every nation highlighted the importance of partnership. No country can singly thrive or protect a region but a joint coordination is required. However, this coordination in leveraging China to initiate an arms

race forces others to join. Once the Indo-Pacific falls into the security dilemma trap, it becomes a vicious cycle where arms build-up is necessary for arms control. Only anti-dote to prevent is again institutionalization itself. When Quad is institutionalized, it can work with other regional partners and ensure China participates in the consultation. In 2002, the conduct of parties in the South China Sea was initiated by ASEAN and China for a rules-based order. However, the consultations have not arrived at a consensus yet. While Quad along with ASEAN, South Pacific, East Asian and China can work towards a conduct of parties and regulatory mechanisms to prevent an arms race and the region's de stability ( Alan Callow, 2024)..

**Strategic variations within Quad**

Quad countries joined hands together to uphold the value-based system in the Indo-Pacific. Yet in real politick the strategic expectation from each partners differs. For US its purely China. US also sees Quad as a legitimate mechanism to exert fluence in a systematic and regulated manner. It also wants to expand the relationship into a defense alliance to create a collective defense organization similar to NATO in the Indo-Pacific. This notion is against the strategic expectations of India and Australia. India wants an absolute rule-based order not under the influence of any states, including the USA. India is currently the largest growing democracy. At the age of its growth, it doesn't want to antagonize any nation and go with a military confrontation. India has also maintained its strategic autonomy policy for decades and is cautious about not portraying Quad as a bloc. It wants more partners and to diversify its interests. This strategic variation between India and USA is a blockade to the institutionalization process. However the difference of opinion is minimal and convergence ins other areas is over lapping the difference. This factor is not an essential blockade to institutionalization at the physical level but exists at a narrative level. India is breaking its past hesitations and taking new steps as a regional leader to ensure best for its national and regional security. Institutionalization has proven to be impactful and help strengthen the Indo-Pacific security framework. Yet India wants this process to happen organically no by the influence or interest of US. India believes this Quad is moving towards that process but wants to structure it decisively. India is focused on diversifying the areas of cooperation within Quad, including more cooperation sectors and increasing more engagement feel it's diluting the anti-China posture of the Quad but helps overall strengthen the Quad for its long-term existence. These strategic variations are only present issues that will fade away in the future when more convergence happens ( Priyanka Mallik, 2024).

**US`s new isolationism in 2025**

Leadership had played a crucial role in the evolution of Quad over the period. The commitment of leaders to speed up the process since 2017 is a critical factor that led to the growth of Quad in such a short period. In 2019 and 2024, elections took place in India, and Mr. Modi's government won. In Australia, the leadership change to Mr. Antony Albanese has contributed positively to the growth of Quad. Japan`s former PM Shin Zo Abe, laid a proper vision of Japan`s role in Quad. In 2020, when a leadership change happened in the US with Mr. Biden becoming the president of the US, the Quad process remained intact.

Mr. Trump laid a foundation for the change of approach of the US on the Indo-Pacific, and Mr. Biden prioritized the natural evolution of the Quad without forcing it to be on American standards. In 2024, Mr. Trump came back to capitol but with a different approach. His campaign analysts argued that Trump might take an isolationist approach and start digging into the conflicts. Mr. Trump`s activities may affect Quad in two ways. First Trump`s forcible the role in Ukraine conflict and Gaza crisis to end the conflict no longer serves the American interest. He questioned the credibility of NATO`s use to America. He has mentioned his interest in de coupling from NATO and asking Europe to take care of its security commitments independently. He had his isolationist approach in Indo-Pacific too. He criticized the US-Japan reciprocal defense treaty as not reciprocal. With South Korea, he mentioned his interest that instead of militarily supporting South Korea he may cut a deal with North Korea that it would not run against the US. He feels US led defense and security partnership are burdening the US exchequer and doesn’t want to fund any nation which does not serve US interest. If he applies same logic to Quad, that from US perspective Quad is only to do with China and instead of empowering other three nations US can directly engage with China either cut a deal to prevent US interest alone and leverage China to be in the way it wants to be in the South China sea. Since Quad has many cooperation and development commitments, he might feel it is burdening and not serving the anti-China campaign. There is a risk of US de coupling from Quad and focusing on other deals such as AUKUS, ANZUS and squad. Second risk factor is that the US leadership can force Quad to have overt security and defense imperatives. So far Quad is evolving naturally by equally accommodating the interest of all four nations. Since overt security commitments do not serve the interests of all four at current developments, it's slowly infusing security imperative without bringing in a defense alliance-like structure. But Trump may force Quad to have defense and security commitments and navigate Quad only in terms

of US interest and not other partners. If he does it will inhibit the natural growth of Quad and may de rail from its vision and values ( Katherine Viner, 2025) .

# Chapter V

# Conclusion

## Summary

The role of Quad in the evolving Indo-Pacific security architecture has evidently proved to be a crucial factor. At times where the international laws and international institution responsible for peace and security are losing their momentum, developments like Quad is a distant ray of hope. Democratic nations which prefers peace and stability are looking for an issue based partnership to fill the void created by the failure of security council and similar organs. Quad in retrospect fills that position to become and effective deterrent partnership in the Indo-Pacific region. Quad though started as a development partnership has slowly evolved to add security impetus to it. Though it refrains from having an overt security commitments it tries to project security for development model. It brings security as pre requisite for development in the Indo-Pacific region and thereby give importance to security.

In international security academia there are traditional and evolving perspective of security. The traditional perspective being state based offensive and defensive security and alliance which were inspired from the cold war model. The evolving perspectives of international security includes newer threats such as terrorism, climate change, supply chain resilience, food and energy security having a dynamic perspective. Quad chose the latter over the traditional since its no more relevant in the Indo-Pacific region. Indo-Pacific which first emerged as an academic discourse later developed as a geographical reality, the region is dynamic and complicated. It includes, South Asia, Southeast Asia, East Asia, South Pacific, Eastern flank of Africa and West Asia. Each region has is own distinctive cultural, regional, national identity. Quad tries to acts as an unifying force paved by growth and development to bring synergy among these region. At this multi plex geography security remains to be a top concern with non state actors taking an aggressive stance and China becoming assertive. At this juncture Quad tries to position as a force for good and force for stability in the region.

The core motto of the Quad remains to be Free, Open, Inclusive Indo-Pacific. A region not under the influence of a single player of a region not serving only a specific interest. A region for growth and prosperity. This ideals of Quad comes in contradiction with China`s ambition in the region to be more assertive and influential. This factor un evidently puts Quad as an anti China bloc. China tries to bring the cold war narrative where USSR is replaced by China and Western bloc remains to be the same. However Quad has proved its is a bloc of none. If it were

to be an US bloc or US alliance the military tension would have been peak at the Indo-Pacific. Rather Quad is natural evolution of democracies which prioritizes development and growth at large. These narrative does not fit any part into the cold war era confrontation. Every Quad member has an equal space in the grouping. Every decision is a product of joint consensus of all the member states. US being a hegemonic power cannot push its hegemonic interest via Quad as the very making of Quad is democratic. It is the reason why US has gone for alternatives such as AUKUS, squad. However these interest based grouping cannot subsume Quad`s position as well.

India`s position plays a crucial role in the security evolution of Quad in the coming future. India has opined that Quad is not a bloc and it should be diversified. If Quad is to be diversified it will gain more international traction and regional consolidation. India`s position in Quad is similar to Gandhi Ji`s strategy for removing imperialism from India. It has chosen a democratic, moral based, collective, ahimsa way of fighting imperialism rather than an over military threat which will intensify the situation. India tries growth by security and thereby establish peace. It is also an effective deterrent for China especially in the border. The way how India want to use Quad on China will be decided upon the state of relations in the northern border of India with China.

Quad will have a strong presence in the Indo-Pacific security architecture. Quad will act as a regulatory valve in the security development o the region. It will not lead to rampant militarization and confrontation or leave the region largely un protected. Rather by the force of participation and consensus it tries to build a peace narrative or peace process in the region which will positively reflect in the Indo-Pacific security. Quad follows security via consensus model where it forges a moral and legal strength to securitize the region. The moral and legal strength is important and prior to arms and ammunitions. Since Chinese interest is largely affected by this process it takes a cold stand of the Quad but from Quad countries perspective it is not anti China or a club of countries it's a development partnership which focuses on peace and security for growth and prosperity. If China were to take a hard stand inhibiting growth, Quad will respond in the way which brings China accountable. If China were to comply with the Quad`s vision on Indo-Pacific Quad countries can also accommodate China on its course of development.

Quad has proven to a steadily evolving partnership which started at an informal level later to grow as at a partnership level and to a proper mini lateral. The signs of institutionalization is

positively reflecting in the Quad`s ambition in the Indo-Pacific security. Quad evolves based on developments of that specific time period and developments. If it gets a sudden institutional structure its foundation and purpose will be un defined and move off the course. But Quad is building its foundation strongly by determining its vision, purpose, the way how it should react to the external developments, means by it which achieves it target. There is an institutional character already present in a nascent stage. The working groups in the implementation level is a strong sign for institutional character. The annual meeting of the head of the states is a commitment by itself which has got an institutional character in planning level. In security perspective as well it has got budding institutional character. The Malabar exercise though not a part of Quad but aligns positively with the interest of Quad. From 2025, the Coast guard interaction and joint exercises among the forces will bring an institutional synergy for a crisis response. The institutionalization process is already evolving naturally and its security development is also evolving parallelly which is complementary to each other.

**Summarizing Answer to Each Research Question:**

**A ) Individual member states interest in Quad`s institutionalization**

1) **Australia:** Australia is a geo politically important player in the Quad. It is situated in the middle of the Indo-Pacific region. Since, 21st century Australia is focusing of defense modernization and working to increase its presence in the Oceans. It aligns with its positioning in the Quad. Australia`s relations with China is also evolving but seeing a dip. Australia is non nuclear power with limited capabilities on long range striking capabilities and man power in military. It find partnerships as an effective means to deter Chinese growth. Initial positions of Australia on Quad institutionalization process was different as it was soft balancing China. As the relations gets worse Australia favours for a gradual and natural institutionalization of Quad but not with overt security commitment. It wants an institutional Quad but not similar to NATO or any other defense alliance. But a Quad with more security impetus string enough to condemn any Chinese aggression in the region.

2) **India:** India`s position in Quad`s institutionalization process is delicate and impactful. Since it share direct land border with China and trying to solve the border issues permanently this decision will be off the card temporarily. India has never been in a military alliance in its history. But India is a partner which portrays Quad as a strong

development and growth partnership. India also wants to diversify Quad which will give more room for institutionalization process. The ways how India looks at Indo-Pacific security aligns with the rules based order and legal protection of sovereignty of all members of Indo-Pacific. India will be open to institutionalize Quad similar to BRICS or other development partnership with a bank or funding agency type. However military commitment or a defense alliance is un likely to happen in the Quad at India`s presence. India wants a strong Quad if Institutionalization process is next option available to make it stronger India will not have any hesitations further on.

3) **Japan**: Japan is an economically influential and geo politically important partner in the Indo-Pacific region. Japan since the tragedy of World War II was in Western bloc and US has shed its nuclear umbrella to Japan. However realizing the need for self sufficiency in national security, Japan has come out of its long standing hesitation and has begun to modernize its army and establish new security partnership. Japan is in favour of institutionalization since Shin Zo Abe`s time. Former PM Abe had the idea of creating Quad as a regional organization to add validity to his confluence of two seas idea. Japan is open for a security partnership and defense relations with Quad as it considers as an effective deterrent vis a vis China. Quad will amplify Japan`s security posture in the Indo-Pacific. Maintaining close security partnership with 2 nuclear powers in the region will increase the deterrent factor. Japan`s participation as permanent member in the Malabar exercise is a strong message that it conveyed to its regional partners. It happened parallelly with North Korea testing its nuclear missiles and often violating the EEZ of Japan. Japan supports the institutionalization process and wants to include more security impetus to the Quad serving the Japan`s interest.

4) **United States of America:** America`s approach towards institutionalization process is slightly different. Though it is in favour of institutionalizing the feature of the process is different. US`s entire approach towards the Indo-Pacific is specifically China centric. Quad from US perspective is a crucial China deterrent. Knowing the fact that US cannot deter China in its own territory without regional members presence it forged a regional partnership via Quad to deter China. Yet, US wants Quad to grow only in retaliation to China unlike India, Australia and Japan. US wants to lead the institutionalization process and infuse its interest via institutionalization. Similar to Japan, the institutionalization process will have importance to security commitment. US sees an

institutional Quad as a prior step to create a NATO like collective defense bloc in Indo-Pacific region. Though it give emphasis to rule based order, free Indo-Pacific it intends to achieve it through the barrel of the gun. If Quad gets institutionalized under US dominance it will spur an arms race in Indo-Pacific. Since India and Australia has a differing opinion US will have to navigate its own partners and build Quad with resilient security commitment under US leadership. US wants an institutional Quad with security impetus in its own leadership.

**B) Impacts of Indo-Pacific Security Architecture upon Quad`s Institutionalization**

1) **Rule Based Order in the Region:** Indo-Pacific is a highly volatile region. Its growing importance in terms of trade and geo politics makes it a pivot of 21st century. However there is a legal regional mechanism ensure rule based order in the region by institutionalization of Quad, it gets legal validity and moral power to ensure rule based order in the region. Institutionalization process effectively aids in enforcement of international laws especially UNCLOS. From freedom of navigation and over flight, supply chain protection, safety of undersea cables a regional organization can provide effective enforcements of international laws.
2) **Deter aggression from individual actors:** Indo-Pacific region is witnessing continuous conflicts especially in maritime domain. Especially in the Eastern flank in the South and East China seas the ASEAN nation gets involved in skirmishes often with China. China`s assertive role in the region and its hegemonic ambitions are clearly visible from its acts and narratives. A strong grouping such as Quad with institutional character will make and individual aggressor accountable for its acts in the region. It establishes a **Cooperative security governance** in the region which will lead to effective governance of vast seas.
3) **Combat evolving issues of international security:** Indo-Pacific region is a mis of developed, developing and under developed economies. There is a systemic difference existing in the polities and economies. Quad as a regional organization can help bringing nations in different pockets for equitable distribution of power and resources. The democratic nature of the organization inspires nations to uphold democratic principles and values. Quad countries are already working on dynamic issues of security such as food security, energy security, climate security. Its role will deepen in helping the developing economies especially South-Pacific and East Africa to battle poverty, mal nutrition and other health crises.

4) **Inclusive Indo-Pacific:** Quad has successfully emerged as a democratic partnership ensuring equal space for all members in the region. Unlike other groupings such as NATO, SCO, which serves primarily for a states interest rather Quad serves regions interests. The making of Quad since 2007 is inclusive and democratic. By institutionalizing Quad it can acts as a force of democracy and inclusivity in the region. It forgers the region with greater synergy helps pacified solution of territorial disputes greater synergy among development initiatives finally ensuring a forged and inclusive region. Indo-Pacific plays a crucial role in the geo-politics of 21st century and a factor like Quad is important to keep it free, inclusive, democratic and safe.

**Findings:**

1) **Quad is an evolving mechanism:** From 2007 to 2025 Quad has shown a positive pattern of growth. Its scope and purpose has widened constantly. In 2007 Quad begin as mere HADR effort, in 2025 Quad is the top regional player of the Indo-Pacific region. It has incorporated security dynamics into its larger purpose carefully. The security impetus of Quad is in constant growth.
2) **Quad is not Asian NATO:** One of the important criticism that Quad faces is that it resembles NATO and China calls it Asian NATO. But there is clear difference between NATO and Quad. NATO is a collective defence grouping where as Quad is a development partnership with security impetus. Its notion of security is not associated with deterrence from a state rather security as a pre requisite for growth.
3) **Quad is Institutionalizing:** Unlike the old time where formal creation of regional organization precedes, the Quad follows an evolving pattern. First from a partnership to defining purpose to creating working groups it ticks all the check boxes of a growth pattern of a mini lateral. With this steady approach, Quad uses the natural momentum of geo politics to get institutionalized.
4) **Quad supports Indo-Pacific Security Architecture:** Quad uses the void in the Indo-Pacific regional security mechanism to find it place. Indo-Pacific is a newly emerging area of importance. It lacked traditional security mechanism unlike Europe and trans Atlantic which was shaped by world wars and cold war. The Quad is seizing the Indo-Pacific momentum to emerge as a responsible regional net security provider of Indo-Pacific.
5) **India`s role in Indo-Pacific is amplified by Quad:** India is the most crucial player in the Indo-Pacific geo politics. India`s strong demographic dividend, resilient economic

growth, increase in diplomatic posture attributes to growth of Indo-Pacific region. India`s interest in Indo-Pacific is strong and profound. With the help of Quad India is gathering collective strength and capital to ensures its interest. The Quad countries and other regional players also recognizes India`s position in Indo-Pacific and expects India to play a greater role in regional geo politics.

6) **Quad is committed to development:** Quad has built a range of working groups especially in terms of development, infrastructure, climate change. The Quad leaders are committed to over all growth of the region in all the spectrum and to build a resilient Indo-Pacific region. It intends to empower the South Pacific region by increasing the bilateral level relations among the South Pacific countries and Quad countries.
7) **Quad is expanding:** The initial credit of building strong foundation of Quad is attributed to Australia, India, Japan, USA. Since the scope and interest of Quad has widened new countries are showing interest in taking part in Quad. Vietnam, new Zealand, South Korea are trusting upon Quad and Quad plus narrative is strengthening. This will provide more opportunity for the Quad in institutionalization as well as securitization process of the Indo-Pacific.

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